

The Empty Space, Sabbateanism, and its Melody
Studies on Liqqutei MoHaRaN (Likutei Moharan) Torah 64
From the literary estate of Joseph Weiss

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Provisional aesthetic choices, unfinished
footnote conversion

If the realm of the non-absolute "difficulty" (קושיא) reveals a facet of laughter, such that it contains within it the entire metaphysics of humour, then this realm should at least have had its own acoustics, albeit stammering, an acoustics of humour. Whereas the realm of the absolute "difficulty" is the dominion of profound silence. From the muteness of silence the "difficulties" come forth and clash with their opposing positions, to fight them to the bitter end. The hidden powers of negation within them—not the stammering laughter, but rather the absolute silence—becomes it.

— Joseph Weiss

Torah 64 is counted among the important teachings in the book **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** by R. Naḥman of Breslov. This Torah has received numerous analyses and commentaries from the pens of various scholars. Each scholar addressed the aspects that seemed to him central not only to the teachings of Breslov Hasidism but to Hasidism in general. The scholar of Hasidism, Joseph Weiss (1918–1969), returned to discuss this Torah several times throughout his life, first extensively and comprehensively in his important essay "The 'Difficulty' (Ha'Qushia) in the Teaching of R. Naḥman." In this essay, Weiss laid out the main tenets of his thoughts on the ideas of R. Naḥman of Breslov, at the center of which stands an inquiry into the concept of the "difficulty" and paradoxical faith.¹ This essay blends with the doctoral dissertation he submitted to Prof. Gershom Scholem in 1951.² Since then, Weiss's positions have received both appreciation and critique. Weiss himself felt that this essay of his was not an exclusive or exhaustive analysis of the profound Torah, as evidenced by the two essays presented here from his literary estate, whose main thrust is additional facets of Torah 64 not previously discussed by him.

Testimony to the process of broadening Weiss's initial approach concerning the study of Breslov Hasidism and the figure of its founder can be found in the lengthy correspondence he had with his beloved teacher, Gershom Scholem. In a letter dated March 26, 1952, Weiss writes from Oxford to Scholem in Jerusalem, words that teach us not only about the aforementioned development but also about his close relationship with Scholem:

"And the main reason for my writing is to ask my master's advice concerning a proposal made to me by the Schocken publishing house over a month ago, to which I have not yet been able to respond. They proposed (in a non-binding manner for them) that they would print my essay on the doctrine of dialectics, etc., as printed in the jubilee volume in honor of Schocken (and I have not yet merited to see this book) and they are even willing to add a new chapter or two. And I am very much deliberating whether to accept their proposal, since fundamental doubts arose for my master primarily concerning the last chapter (the chapter on Faith), and even in the earlier chapters there is room for correction as my master informed me. What has been printed has been printed and cannot be taken back, but to reprint these things, which I would write differently today, I doubt whether it is proper, or wise. And from this perspective, it seems to me better to give a negative answer to the Schocken publishing house. [...] As for the question of publishing parts of the doctorate, there is no difference whether three chapters or four chapters of it are published, and in any case it seems to me that the entire matter should be rewritten anew [...] according to additional points of view (which do not negate the points of view of my first writing, but deepen them or 'tighten' them more). Indeed, I have nothing definitive to write about R. Naḥman, and of necessity everything will have a segmentary character (Segmentcharakter), both due to

¹ J. Weiss, "The 'Difficulty' in the Teaching of R. Naḥman," **'Alē 'Ayin: Minḥat Dvarim li-Shelomo Zalman Shoken** (1948–1952), pp. 245–291. The essay was reprinted in his book: **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, edited by M. Piekartz, Jerusalem 1975, pp. 109–149.

² J. Weiss, **The Doctrine of Dialectic and Faith of R. Naḥman of Breslov**, dissertation for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy, The Hebrew University, Jerusalem 1951. 138 pages.

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the shortness of what is grasped and the depth of the concept. Why, then, wait 8 years for publication and finally publish something which, at the time of its publication, I no longer stand in that same examination? And if I wait until 'everything' is clarified and elucidated—my life will be consumed and the subject will not. The late printing (after 8 years) of my first view brings me to these reflections and spurs me to print in the sense of 'it is not incumbent upon you to finish the work.' And therefore I have considered publishing the third chapter of the doctoral dissertation in *Tarbiz* (without those appendices that my master rejects). This chapter has something of outlining the new direction I began three years ago, the psychological and mythological direction instead of the philosophical direction in the study of Breslov Hasidism. And I admit that the act of *Entmythologisierung* (demythologization) of my initial engagement with the subject was inadequate (and in this I see the main weakness of my essay as it appeared in the Schocken volume)."³

Scholem's response to this letter has not been preserved, but part of it can be reconstructed from Weiss's reply to the missing letter (letter undated. Scholem wrote at its head: June, 1952). And these are Weiss's words:

"My soul is not pleased with my master's words, which are a double-edged sword, in his last letter to me: 'It is good that your essay in the Schocken volume will stand for debate and I am assured that the matters will make an impression on serious readers. If I am not mistaken, it will contribute to serious clarification. Certainly I do not agree to the distinction between naïve faith and paradoxical faith, etc.' And if my words stand for debate, like everything printed in the world of scholarship, why should I not debate with myself, since it has become clear to me several arguments against myself, and why am I forbidden to correct myself. And truthfully I will say that most of my arguments against myself are precisely not concerning the section on Faith but in the first chapters in which I interpreted several texts that today I would interpret differently and in a more concrete form. It

seems that the presentation of the philosophical problem was not adequate to the subject (or at least not at this stage of research) and everything requires new clarification from a psychological perspective and afterwards from a mythological perspective. And consequently the entire work requires rewriting, and I will not be satisfied in any way with the corrections required by my master. Chapter three of the doctoral dissertation is written not from a philosophical perspective but from a psychological one (this difference is noticeable to anyone who studies my work, and it was indeed written 6 years after writing the other chapters) and now it is necessary to proceed from this matter and deepen the psychology to the point of mythology because all of *Liqqutei MoHaRaN* is nothing but a series of mythological or psychological experiments on himself, and this perception had already dawned on me beforehand and I hinted at it in my introductory words to *Ma'agalē Siah* (Small Library of Schocken Publishing [Jerusalem and Tel Aviv 1948]). And until I write everything anew, it is incumbent upon me to criticize myself (and it will be more comprehensive than my master's criticism! and sharper!), so as not to lead others astray, God forbid—and self-criticism is a great commandment also in the people's democracies."⁴

At the head of the essay "Studies in the Self-Perception of R. Naḥman" (1958), which is none other than the chapter mentioned in the letter to Scholem, Weiss writes similar things:

"The starting point for the development of the dialectic is not the world and creation but the possessor of the dialectic himself."

And he adds in a note:

"The reader of these words who compares them to what I wrote in my essay 'The "Difficulty" in the Teaching of R. Naḥman of Breslov' [...] will not err if he discerns the change in perspective between here and there. There I labored to establish the dialectic on the starting point of the

³ The National and University Library in Jerusalem, Department of Manuscripts, Gershom Scholem Archive.

⁴ Ibid.

creation of the world and its structure. Further study of the Breslov texts revealed to me that there is yet another mythological layer beyond the ontological layer clarified in my aforementioned essay: at the starting point of the creation of the world, R. Nahman finds himself. The mythic egocentrism, that is, that which builds myth, is the only key that opens for the reader of the Breslov writings the gates of understanding. From the perspective of my current essay, my previous words in the book *'Alē 'Ayin* have an element of 'demythologization' (Entmythologisierung in foreign language). It is not my intention to blur the fundamental difference between my first approach and my approach here, or to claim that my first doctrine has not moved from its place. In light of the perspective in my current essay, it is possible to return and clarify several points in which my first words were too vague, and it seems to me possible to fill them with complete mythic concreteness. And this is not the place to elaborate."⁵

This insight did not pass over his understanding of Torah 64 either, and in 1962 Weiss wrote about this Torah:

"I analyzed the ontological aspects of this Torah, which speaks of two types of heresy (apikorsut), or as formulated in the first printing—two types of denial of the living God (כפירה באלקים חיים), one coming from external wisdom and one coming from a higher realm, in my essay on the 'difficulty' in the teaching of R. Nahman. And the matter requires further clarifications, because the ontological aspect does not exhaust the Torah 'Come unto Pharaoh' (בא אל פרעה), and one must add the 'zadikological' aspect (האספקט הצדיקולוגי)."⁶

Weiss indeed continued to research Torah 64 in the course of his journey from new perspectives, and he uncovered new layers in it. If in his first research he highlighted the issue of the "difficulty," in the later course of his path he emphasized additional important components in this Torah, arising from emphasizing the place and value of the *zadik*.

And they are: silence, the melody (*niggun*), and the issue of the relationship and connection to Sabbateanism.

The very existence of additional essays on Torah 64 highlights Weiss's path as a scholar who returned to re-discuss the sources before him in different periods and from different perspectives. One can also learn from this about the complexity of Weiss's research, which raised new elements in each reading that he had not illuminated previously. The absence of these and other subjects in his researches does not stem, therefore, from a deliberate and mobilized "ignorance" that led him to omit certain passages in his citations, as some have claimed, and one must understand Weiss's world in a more complex manner. Certainly one should not summarize and see Weiss's conception as an expression of existentialist thought and nothing more, and that he interpreted the thought of R. Nahman solely in this spirit, while ignoring other aspects and even dismissing them out of hand. Similarly, it is impossible to illuminate the entirety of Weiss's writing only in light of his early essay from 1953: "Hasidism of Mysticism and Hasidism of Faith," since its writing, and certainly since its printing, Weiss added and developed many deep layers in his research. Some of these aspects merited publication already in 1975 (in the Hebrew collection of his studies) and in 1985 (in the English collection of his studies), and others remained in his literary estate. Statements such as that Weiss "did not see correctly the full context of Breslov faith" are emptied of content when viewing Weiss's research in its full context.

The issue of developments in Weiss's view characterizes to a large extent the entirety of the writings that remained in his literary estate and were not printed during his lifetime. In these writings, an additional layer is revealed

⁵ J. Weiss, "Studies in the Self-Perception of R. Nahman," *Tarbiz* 27 (1958), pp. 358–371, reprinted in: Weiss, *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 150–171.

⁶ "The Last Chapter in the Life of R. Nahman," *ibid.*, p. 65.

that complements his printed essays and presents a richer picture of his manner of understanding the spiritual world of R. Naḥman of Breslov. Weiss went through the book **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** several times and began to discuss the teachings systematically according to cross-sectional topics, among them: 'Rectification of the Paradox,' 'Possibility of Frankist Hints,' 'Revelation and Concealment,' 'The Shell Preceded the Fruit' and more. Other teachings were interpreted by him not in connection to cross-sectional topics but on their own. An interesting topic that recurs in the writings from the estate is the attempt to find Frankist hints in the writings of R. Naḥman and to clarify R. Naḥman's relationship to Sabbateanism and its offshoots. This topic was not discussed by Weiss in the studies printed during his lifetime, and also the passages printed on this subject were selected by Gershom Scholem from Weiss's estate when editing the volume of his studies in 1975. Thus, in a passage printed from the estate, Weiss wrote:⁷

"It is very possible, and perhaps even plausible, that research will continue to discover in his [R. Naḥman's] doctrine strong elements of the Sabbatean-Frankist doctrine

which he fought to rectify its sin. Elements that adhered to his thought."⁸

Research that he himself continued to develop in several hidden essays,⁹ and on which he gave several lectures that have not been printed until now.

Weiss's renewed engagement with Torah 64 should therefore be understood in the broad context of an attempt to present an analysis of most of the teachings in **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** in additional aspects.

The essays before us have new and fascinating facets. The first essay, "The Empty Space," focuses on the figure of the *zadik*, his silence and his melody in the face of the empty space, in a messianic context; whereas in the second essay, "Sabbateanism and its Melody,"¹⁰ Weiss raises the question of the connection between Breslov doctrine and Sabbateanism and its offshoots and proposes a new interpretive path for Torah 64 in which the struggle with Sabbateanism occupies a central place.

The printing of these essays is part of the preparation of a volume of studies from the literary estate of Joseph Weiss. Two short chapters were published in the newspaper

⁷ J. Weiss, "Hasidism of Mysticism and Hasidism of Faith," **Values of Judaism: A Collection of Lectures**, Tel Aviv 1953, pp. 81–90, reprinted in: Weiss, **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, pp. 87–95, with an additional subtitle: "A Typological Clarification." Such an attitude towards Weiss's research appears in the book of Ch. Mark, **Mysticism and Madness in the Work of R. Naḥman of Breslov**, Tel Aviv 2004 (according to the index). For a slightly more complex position, see R. Margolin, **The Sanctuary of Man: The Internalization of Religiosity and the Shaping of Inner Religious Life in Early Hasidism**, Jerusalem 2005, pp. 41–44.

⁸ Weiss, "First Life Stations and the Beginning of the Controversy," **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, p. 34.

⁹ See also Weiss's lecture from 1969: J. Weiss, 'Sense and Nonsense in Defining Judaism: The Strange Case of Naḥman of Breslav', **Studies in East European Jewish Mysticism**, ed. D. Goldstein, Oxford 1985, pp. 249–269. This book was reprinted with an introduction by Joseph Dan, under the title: **Studies in East European Jewish Mysticism and Hasidism**, London and Portland 1997.

¹⁰ See also the words of Joseph Dan, "The Dual Face of Messianism in Hasidism," in **In the Circles of Hasidim: A Collection of Studies in Memory of Professor Mordecai Wilensky**, edited by I. Etkes, D. Assaf, Y. Bartal, A. Reiner, Jerusalem 2000, p. 300 note 4; and: J. Dan, 'Joseph Weiss Today', **Studies in East European Jewish Mysticism and Hasidism**, ed. D. Goldstein, London and Portland 1997, p. XII. For a description of the state of research on this issue, see below, "Sabbateanism and its Melody," note 9.

Haaretz;¹¹ and additional chapters will appear in a book marking twenty years since the death of Gershom Scholem.¹²

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We have brought the essays as they are, aside from minor linguistic and orthographic corrections. Notes and additions by the editors are brought in angled brackets < >. The titles of the essays are ours.

¹¹ J. Weiss, "The Empty Space," Department of Manuscripts, The National and University Library in Jerusalem, 1479 4, file 57.

¹² Ibid., "Sabbateanism and its Melody." Ibid., file 77.

¹³ "'I Prefer to Be Esoteric': Joseph Weiss and the Tale of the Seven Beggars," *Haaretz*, Culture and Literature, Eve of Shavuot (5.6.2003), p. 2; 'A Breslov-Kafkaesque Story by Joseph Weiss', *Haaretz*, Culture and Literature, Eve of Yom Kippur (5.10.2003), p. 2.

¹⁴ 'Possibility of Frankist Hints in the Teaching of R. Nahman of Breslov: Three Hidden Passages from the Joseph Weiss Archive; Words of Peace or The Life of MoHaRaSh: A Satirical Composition from the Archives of Joseph Weiss', *A Book Marking Twenty Years Since the Death of Gershom Scholem (Jerusalem Studies in Jewish Thought* 20), edited by J. Dan, Jerusalem 2005 [in print].

The Empty Space, Joseph Weiss

The Torah 64 in **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** [Part] I has an important parallel from R. Naḥman's own manuscript. This parallel was printed not long ago in the pamphlet (not a book!) **Liqqutei MoHaRaN: Torahs from the Manuscript of Our Rabbi, of Blessed Memory**, Jerusalem 1934, pp. 5–7.¹⁵ Although the parallel is deficient, as testified by the publisher, nevertheless it is of some assistance in understanding the version in **Liqqutei MoHaRaN**, Torah 64.

Several sharp formulations are worth using to highlight the general intent of the Torah, which finds more powerful expression in the manuscript version. However, it must be emphasized that the manuscript version is not a complete parallel to what was printed. Not only is it deficient in a technical sense, i.e., missing about half a page near the beginning of the Torah, but it is also deficient in terms of its conceptual structure. There is no doubt that the manuscript version reflects an earlier stage of the Torah than the form printed in **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** I, Torah 64. If you wish to say, we have here an earlier cell for the formation of the Torah, which developed further until it reached its printed form. Several fundamental

concepts of the Torah as it stands before us in print in **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** 64 are not found in the manuscript version or are found there in a completely unripe form. The entire developed doctrine of melody in the printed version is completely lacking in the manuscript; the fundamental concept of "Infinite Light" (אור אין סוף) is hardly mentioned at all, or mentioned incidentally without the great importance attributed to this concept in the print. Certainly, the manuscript does not speak of faith in the Infinite Light as the supreme faith among all faiths, as it is in the print. The entire Torah is simpler in the manuscript, and the great complication is characteristic specifically of the printed version. Without entering here into a detailed philological comparison, we can dispense with the parallel in our following analysis, because it is only an expression of the initial sprouting of the Torah, whose ripe form we will analyze in what follows. However, here and there we will note the manuscript version and resort to it if there seems to be benefit for essential clarification.

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¹⁵ <Book **Liqqutei MoHaRaN: Torahs from the Manuscript of Our Rabbi, of Blessed Memory**, Jerusalem 1934, pp. 5–7. The supplements were given to print by Shmuel Horowitz. On this book see N. T. Kœnig, **Book Neveh Tzadikim**, Bnei Brak 1969, p. 77; D. Assaf, **Breslov: Annotated Bibliography**, Jerusalem 2000, p. 4 letter B. Most of the different versions of the teachings that appear in the aforementioned pamphlet, and other additions, were appended to the later editions of the book **Liqqutei MoHaRaN**. See also the annotated edition of Torah 64 in the form of a Talmud page, the work of Y.M.N., **Come unto Pharaoh is Torah 64 from the Book Liqqutei MoHaRaN and Accompanying It Liqqutei Biurim**, Jerusalem 2001. On the editing and printing of **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** I, and the different printings of the book, see J. Weiss, "The Order of Printing of **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** I," **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, edited by M. Piekartz, Jerusalem 1975, pp. 251–256; "The Preparation of **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** I for Print," *ibid.*, pp. 257–277; on the difference between the first printing (1808) and the second printing (1821), see further "A Secret Scroll on the Order of the Coming of the Messiah," *ibid.*, pp. 190–191, and note 6, which also includes the words of Piekartz. Weiss notes that the one responsible for the changes between the editions was R. Nathan, and as he says: "The philological work of comparing **Liqqutei MoHaRaN** first printing with the second printing has not yet been done, and when it is done it will become clear how fundamental R. Nathan's editing was, which touched in several places even on the language and style of the Torah," *ibid.*, p. 275, and he adds in note 56: "G. Scholem already noted [...] that 'this printing [1821] is the most orderly one'. And indeed this printing is a new creation of R. Nathan." See G. Scholem, **Pamphlet These Are the Names, The Books of Our Rabbi Naḥman, of Blessed Memory, of Breslov and the Books of His Disciples and Disciples' Disciples**, Jerusalem 1928, p. 13 number 34. Weiss already used the textual variants of Torah 64 throughout his essay: "The 'Difficulty' in the Teaching of R. Naḥman of Breslov," **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, pp. 109–149.>

The discussion on the ontology of the "difficulty" (קושיא) is concluded,¹⁶ and the special matter opens: the application of the entire discussed Torah to the personality of R. Nahman and the seeking of justification for a biographical fact: R. Nahman's reading of research and heretical books. Beginning from letter (3) ג onward, you find a complicated justification for the fact that R. Nahman studied books containing the two types of heresy (apikorsut). The *zadik*—not every *zadik*, but the special *zadik* who is "of the aspect of Moses," i.e., R. Nahman himself—not only is it permitted for him to study heretical books, but it is incumbent upon him to study them, because his entry into this realm of impurity is a mission: in this he "raises up" souls sunk in this impurity. It is not clear if he refers to souls of the dead or to souls of people living with us today. And furthermore, it is worth mentioning that this Torah does not trouble the great *zadik* in order to save those sunk in the first heresy, i.e., the non-absolute heresy. Apparently, they must extract themselves through logical reasoning. In Torah 62, letter (2) ב, it is said about the "difficulty" that there is an answer to it, because one must investigate it. One must sharpen the intellect regarding it, and it is considered a great commandment.¹⁷

"But know, if there is a great *zadik*, who is of the aspect of Moses, he specifically needs to study these heretical matters, and even though it is impossible to resolve them as mentioned, nonetheless, through his study that he studies there, he raises up from there several souls that fell and sank into this heresy."¹⁸

Formally, we have here a Torah according to the format of the Hasidic Torah on the descent of the *zadik* for the purpose of raising up those sunk in sin.¹⁹ I tried to show elsewhere²⁰ that this Hasidic Torah has two formulations in the time of the early growth of the movement: A) The active conception of the Torah: the *zadik* sometimes "descends" in his thought into the realm of impurity, sin, or a low level in general, out of his mystical intention "to rectify," "to raise up" thereby the souls sunk in that realm of impurity, sin, or low level in general. The *zadik*'s descent of salvation into the realm of sin is only in thought or at most in a fleeting transgression. This is the formulation close to the Sabbatean format of the doctrine of the Messiah's descent into the depths of the "shells" (kelipot) in order to raise them up. B) The passive conception of the *zadik*'s descent: more than he descends, his social environment lowers the *zadik* into the realm of sinful thoughts through its gross, great transgressions. In Breslov doctrine, both formulations recur

¹⁶ <The essay before us is apparently part of a lecture series on R. Nahman, preceded by a discussion on the "difficulty" in Torah 64. Weiss devoted the following essays to the subject of the "difficulty" in R. Nahman's teaching: "In the Thicket of R. Nahman of Breslov's 'Difficulty'," *Haaretz*, 14 Tishrei 5707 (9 October 1946), p. 5; "The 'Difficulty' in the Teaching of R. Nahman of Breslov," *'Alē 'Ayin: A Gift of Words to Shelomo Zalman Schocken* (1948–1952), pp. 245–291. The latter essay was reprinted in his book: *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 109–149.>

¹⁷ <*Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 62, letter ב: "For the truth is that which the Blessed Name limited for the human intellect to be able to understand, it is a great commandment to sharpen the intellect, to understand the matter thoroughly, and about this it is said (Avot 2:14): 'Know what to answer a heretic (אפיקורס).' For there is a distinction between the difficulties; for there is a difficulty that a person can understand a resolution for this difficulty—about this it is said: 'Know what' etc. And there is a difficulty, that it is not possible for the human intellect to understand a resolution for such a difficulty, only in the future to come the resolution will be revealed—it is forbidden for a person to study them. And anyone who relies on his intellect and studies it, about him it is said (Proverbs 2): 'All who come to her shall not return [...]'>

¹⁸ *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter ג.

¹⁹ See analysis of the idea in my essay "The Beginning of the Growth of the Hasidic Path," *Zion* 16 (1951), pp. 46–105 <reprinted in the collection: *Chapters in the Doctrine of Hasidism and its History*, edited by A. Rubinstein, Jerusalem 1978, pp. 122–181. See also M. Piekarz, *In the Days of the Growth of Hasidism: Ideological Trends in Books of Homily and Morality*, Jerusalem 1978, according to the index.>

²⁰ Weiss, "The Beginning of the Growth of the Hasidic Path."

together, but the passive conception does not have decisive weight here. It is found in several places in the pages of the book *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*—but not in the central teachings of this book.

Primary conceptual importance is attributed in Breslov to the second (correction: first) formulation, which is the purposive formulation of the Torah: the *zadik* descends in order "to raise up," in order "to rectify" souls there. The idea that the Torah "Come unto Pharaoh" develops is formally found within the format of the general doctrine of the *zadik*'s descent. In terms of content, there is a difference, for the general Hasidic formulation, as in the descent of the *zadik*, is concerned with rectifying those sunk in transgression, whereas Breslov doctrine as formulated in the Torah "Come unto Pharaoh" deals with rectifying souls sunk in heresy. And another difference: in Breslov doctrine, the *zadik* does not simply descend, but specifically the special great *zadik*, R. Naḥman himself alone. However, in the general structure, Breslov doctrine undoubtedly follows the general Hasidic Torah:

"And therefore, from this second heresy [which has no answer], one certainly needs to be more and more careful to flee and escape from there, not to study and look at their words at all, because, God forbid, he will certainly sink there, for about him it is said: *All who come to her shall not return* etc. as mentioned."²¹

"But know, if there is a great *zadik*, who is of the aspect of Moses, he specifically needs to study these heretical matters. And even though it is impossible to resolve them as mentioned, nonetheless, through his study that he studies there, he raises up from there several souls that fell and sank into this heresy. [...] And therefore the *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses, of the aspect of silence, can study these

perplexing matters, which are of the aspect of silence as mentioned, and he specifically needs to study, in order to raise up the souls that fell there as mentioned."²²

²¹ *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, end of letter ג.

²² Ibid., letter א.

(B)

The great *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses—why specifically must he study the realm of absolute difficulties? Why specifically is this mission of descent for the purpose of raising up imposed upon him? The realm of difficulties that have no answer was already defined above as the realm of mute silence. We found above that the muteness of silence is the acoustic parallel to the absolute logical paradox.^(^24) In letter *א*, R. Nahman develops the idea that the great *zadik* is also of the aspect of silence—therefore it is fitting for one who is of the aspect of silence to enter the dominion of silence!

"And as we find concerning Moses (Menahot 29b), when he asked about the death of R. Akiva: 'This is Torah and this is its reward?' They answered him: 'Be silent! Thus it arose in thought.' That is, you must be silent and not ask an answer and resolution for this difficulty. For thus it arose in thought, which is above speech; therefore you must be silent about this question, because it is of the aspect 'arose in thought,' where there is no speech to resolve it. And similarly, those difficulties and perplexities that come from the empty space, where there is no speech nor intellect as mentioned, therefore they are of the aspect of silence, and one must only believe and be silent there. And therefore it is forbidden to enter and study these heretical and perplexing matters except for a *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses, because Moses is of the aspect of silence, in the aspect that he is called 'heavy of mouth' (Exodus 4), the aspect of silence that is above speech. And therefore the *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses, of the aspect of silence, can study these perplexing matters, which are of the aspect of silence as mentioned, and he specifically needs to study, in order to raise up the souls that fell there as mentioned."^(^25)

In this passage, the meaning of the ambiguous phrase "Moses who is of the aspect of silence" is also clarified. It means that Moses himself is

silent and does not ask. It is fitting for the silent one to enter silence. In this passage, it is clearest that the *zadik* is the one who is silent—the silence of the *zadik*, he is silent, not that they are silent about him.

(C)

In the continuation of the discussion—through a complicated interpretive method that is not our concern to detail here—the secret of the empty space is identified with the secret of the controversy between the sages, that is, the *zadikim*. Everything said about the realm of the empty space as the realm of absolute problematics is henceforth applied also to the controversy between the *zadikim*, and in truth to **the** controversy, the great controversy of the *zadikim* of the generation against R. Nahman.^(^26)

"And so it is with the aspect of controversies, for if all the Torah scholars were one, there would be no place for the creation of the world, only through the controversy between them, and they are divided from one another, and each one draws himself to a different side, through this is made between them the aspect of the empty space, which is the aspect of the contraction of the light to the sides, within which is the creation of the world through speech as mentioned. For all the matters that each one of them speaks, they are all only for the sake of the creation of the world, which is made through them within the empty space between them, for the Torah scholars create everything through their words."^(^27)

Hear from this: The arguments in the controversy against him are absolute arguments that have no answer. It seems that the conduct "But one must be careful not to speak excessively, only according to the need of the creation of the world, no more"^(^28) applies to the *zadik* (and not to those who dispute him), i.e., the *zadik* must be careful not to increase the fire of controversy with many open words. This is a warning to the esotericism of uttering Torah—in order to prevent the controversy from flaring up in all its intensity:

"For through the excess of light, that the vessels could not bear the excess of light, they

broke, and from the breaking of the vessels came^(^29) the formation of the 'shells' (*kelipot*); so too, if one speaks excessively, from this he causes the formation of the 'shells,' for it is the aspect of excess light, through which there was the breaking of the vessels, through which is the formation of the 'shells.'"^(^30)

It is not clear if the intent of the words is actual "shells" or the cause of controversy, and there is no great difference between them for our concern.

R. Nahman returns to the conduct of warning of minimal speech in Torah that is incumbent upon him, the *zadik* upon whom controversy has flared up "between sages," in another form nearby, in interpreting the Mishnah "All my days I grew up among the sages, and I have not found for the body anything better than silence" etc.^(^31)

"Among the sages, this is the aspect of the empty space, which came into being and was made between the sages through the separation and controversy that is between them as mentioned. [...] And I have not found for the body anything better than silence, for there, in the empty space, there is nothing better than silence as mentioned, because it is forbidden to enter there except for one who is of the aspect of silence, the aspect of Moses as mentioned. And this is what he said: 'All my days I grew up among the sages and I have not found etc.,' for through his holding of this level, of the aspect of silence, as he said that there is nothing better than silence, therefore his days and his attributes grew there in the empty space, because it is forbidden to enter there except for one who is of the aspect of silence as mentioned."^(^32)

Are these words identical in intent with what was said above concerning the conduct of caution in speech, i.e., in uttering Torah that should be with minimal speech? It seems to me that there, the hint to light that needs to be

little, is completely clear that it refers to Torah uttered from the mouth of the *zadik*. Whereas the homily on the Mishnah "All my days I grew up etc." can be interpreted also in another manner, i.e., that the *zadik* must be silent not about his Torah (for it is impossible to be completely silent about Torah, and also above it spoke of minimizing this matter of speech and not complete silence) but about the controversy—the aspect of the empty space that flared up against the *zadik*. That is to say: the *zadik* who is of the aspect of silence does not answer his revilers anything, does not resolve the difficulties of the controversy of those who dispute him. These difficulties are of the aspect of the empty space, i.e., there is no answer to them; the difficulties are absolute, and justification is out of place! If this is the interpretation of the words here, and not merely self-warning to conduct caution in uttering Torah, then the meaning of the words is: the paradoxical *zadik* does not justify himself and does not apologize in the face of controversy, but is silent!

\(^30\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter 7.

\(^31\) Avot, 1.

\(^32\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter 7.

\(^24\) <See on this further Weiss, "The 'Difficulty' in the Teaching of R. Naḥman," *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 139–141.>

\(^25\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter 1.

\(^26\) <On the matter of controversy, see further J. Weiss, "R. Naḥman of Breslov [on] [and] the Controversy about Him," *Studies in Kabbalah and the History of Religions Presented to Gershom Scholem on His Eightieth Birthday*, Jerusalem 1968, pp. 101–114. Reprinted with additions, in: Weiss, *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 42–57. See also his essay printed from the estate, "First Life Stations and the Beginning of the Controversy," *ibid.*, pp. 5–41.>

\(^27\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter 7.

\(^28\) *Ibid.*

\(^29\) Thus in the first printing, and in new printings 'was'.

(D)

And perhaps the second possible interpretation of the words interpreting the Mishnah should be preferred—i.e., that their intent is to depict before us not the *zadik* minimizing his words of Torah, but to depict the paradoxical *zadik* who is silent—this interpretation is more acceptable not only because of the powerful image hidden within it, over which a true Breslov spirit hovers, but this interpretation is more acceptable to reason because of the complete parallel between it and a passage in the **Tales** (Sippurei Ma'asiyot). This parallelism recommends my second interpretation: I refer to this passage in "The Seven Beggars" (זיין בעטליר"ש) in which the depiction of the silent *zadik* facing those who dispute him appears in all the glory of its mighty splendor:

"And one said that his silence is the aspect of 'the little that holds much,' for there are many accusers against him and many slanderers who inform against him very much, and all that they inform and speak and accuse against him with much slander, he, through his silence, resolves everything through the fact that he is merely silent (for he does only some silence and it is a resolution for everything). Hence, his silence is the little that holds much."(^33\)

The passage in **Liquṭei <MoHaRaN>** I <Torah 64> does not always define the nature and essence of the controversy; we do not hear why the controversy broke out or to what type the arguments of the disputants belong. Is the intent of the words that the argument is the great *zadik*'s study, who is of the aspect of Moses, in heretical books? Seemingly it appears so, but I do not mean to say that this point is completely clear according to the simple meaning of the words of Torah 64 or according to clear hints. And what is the nature of the heretical books, the study of which is considered sufficient reason to arouse controversy? Are they books of philosophical research or books of theological heresy of

another type, or both together? Or perhaps the basis of the controversy is not the reading that the great *zadik* of the aspect of Moses reads in certain heretical books? In opening his ideas on the controversy between sages, which is of the aspect of the empty space, R. Nahman does not explicitly link the arousal of the controversy with the *zadik*'s study in heretical books, and this connection is merely a hypothesis. It is possible that the controversy is based on stronger arguments against the *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses, that he is the great actor who studies what he studies—and nevertheless, the controversy does not argue about his study but about other things? We cannot say anything clear about its character on this point. We cannot prove according to the text before us that the controversy is connected to the *zadik*'s study in philosophical research books, or in other heretical books, or other arguments.

\(^33\) **Sippurei Ma'asiyot le-Rabi Nahman mi-Breslev**, with introduction by S. A. Horodetzky, Berlin 1922, p. 161, tale of the fifth day of 'The Tale of the Seven Beggars', tale 13, **Book Sippurei Ma'asiyot**, published by Agudat Meshekh HaNaḥal, Jerusalem 1985, p. 269–270.>

(E)

In the continuation of the presentation, it becomes clear that the great *zadik* performs the rectification action incumbent upon him through his melody (*niggun*):

"And know that through the melody of the *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses, he raises up the souls from this heresy of the empty space that fell there."(^34\)

This is not the place to give a detailed analysis of the concept of melody in Breslov doctrine. This is one of the topics most beloved by popular research, and therefore melody will not be missing its place in all those anthologies and descriptions, nevertheless it is difficult to say that any attempt has been made to analyze the Breslov concept of melody with its various meanings that I could rely on from prior investigation. (^35\) I am compelled by the necessity of presenting my problem; I will not exhaust the discussion on the concept of melody here but will hint at several aspects relevant to the question we are discussing.

The general foundation of the doctrine of melody establishes the melody in its two functions: A) As the principle of individuation. B) As the root and source of every wisdom and wisdom, without distinction of the essence of the wisdom. This principle is so general that it does not allow for difference and change between a wisdom of Torah and a wisdom of heresy: formally, even a wisdom of heresy and heresy is a wisdom, and all the general laws of wisdom apply to it:

"For know, that every wisdom and wisdom in the world has a particular melody (זמר), (^36\) that this melody is particular to this wisdom. And from this melody this wisdom is drawn, and this is the aspect (Psalms 47:8) *Sing a maskil*; that every wisdom and wisdom has a melody, and even the wisdom of heresy has a melody particular to the heretical wisdom. And this is what our sages said (Ḥagigah 15b):

'What became of him? A Greek melody never ceased from his mouth, and when he rose from the study hall, how many heretical books fell from him.' For this depends on this, for through the aforementioned melody that never ceased from his mouth, through this the heretical books fell from him, for this melody was particular to this heresy and heresy that he had. Hence, every wisdom and wisdom according to its aspect and level, so it has a melody belonging and particular to it. And so from level to level."(^37\)

(^34\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter נ at its beginning.

(^35\) <Weiss refers to the research of S. A. Horodetzky, S. M. Gshuri and others. Weiss devoted a short essay to the doctrine of melody, which was printed from his estate, see J. Weiss, "Rectification of the Melody of the Wicked or the Controversy of Saul and David," *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 58–60. On melody in Breslov doctrine, see further the items noted by Assaf, *Breslov: Annotated Bibliography*, pp. 214–215. To these should be added A. Y. Green, *Tormented Master: A Life of Rabbi Nahman of Bratslav*, Tel Aviv 1990, in appendices; Y. Liebes, "The General Rectification of R. Naḥman of Breslov and its Relation to Sabbateanism," *Zion* 45 (1980), pp. 236–238; and Ch. Mark, "Silence and Melody in the Face of the Empty Space in the Writings of R. Naḥman of Breslov," *Kabbalah: Journal for the Study of Jewish Mystical Texts* 7 (2002), pp. 175–197; idem, *Mysticism and Madness in the Work of R. Naḥman of Breslov*, Tel Aviv 2004, pp. 257–280.>

(^36\) In later printings here and everywhere else 'melody and *niggun*', but the word '*niggun*' is not in the first printing.

(^37\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter נ. <Here Weiss added in the margin: 'Bring further parallel places on melody.'>

(F)

All these preliminaries about melody of wisdom and melody of wisdom of heresy and heresy are only worthwhile to prepare the pinnacle of the matter: the wisdom of the highest level also has its own melody.

To which type does this supreme wisdom belong, to the wisdoms or to the wisdoms of heresy and heresy? For the existence of a particular melody even for a wisdom of heresy and heresy was emphasized with excessive emphasis a few lines before!

"And so from level to level. For the aspect of the wisdom of the highest level has a more supreme melody according to its aspect, and so higher and higher until the beginning point of creation, which is the beginning of emanation (Azilut), and there is nothing above it, and there is no encompassing (makiif) for that wisdom that is there except the Infinite Light (Ohr Ein Sof) that encompasses the empty space, within which are all the creations and wisdoms. And certainly also there is an aspect of wisdom, but the wisdom that is there in the Infinite Light cannot be known and grasped, for the Infinite (Ein Sof) is the Blessed Name Himself, and His wisdom cannot be grasped at all, and there is only the aspect of faith, that they believe in Him, may He be blessed, that His Infinite Light surrounds all worlds and encompasses everything."(^38\)

We have reached the beginning of creation with which Torah 64 opens. Above everything is the Infinite (Ein Sof) and its light, which is the Infinite Light. This Infinite Light encompasses everything, that is to say, it encompasses even the empty space, the source of all absolute difficulties that have no answer. Hear from this that the Infinite Light is above even the empty space. The Infinite Light is the most problematic in the world, most open to every difficulty and problem. There is no place there except for faith—to grasp the Infinite Light through intellectual means is completely

impossible. What the Infinite Light is—not according to its logical structure but according to its concrete content—we do not learn for now. However, it is worth noting the great blurring between God and the Infinite Light and the lack of precision to distinguish between the Infinite, which is apparently identical in the text with God, and the Infinite Light, so that one could write: "that they believe in Him, may He be blessed, that His Infinite Light surrounds all worlds" etc. Is there only imprecision of formulation here, a lack of desire or lack of attention to sharply distinguish between God and the Infinite Light? This lack of clarity reflects conceptual unclarity to distinguish between God and the Infinite Light?

(G)

The next step establishes that faith also belongs to the entire structure of wisdom, from at least one perspective: also to faith, to every faith and faith, belongs a particular melody of its own. The parallel is complete through this, that faith too is grasped formally, without considering the content of the faith. Through this, it becomes possible to include also faiths of idolatry within the general framework of faiths:

"And faith also has a melody^(^39) particular to the faith. And as we see that even the faiths of idolaters in matters of error^(^40)—for every faith of idolaters there is a particular melody that they sing with and arrange in their house of prayer—so too, conversely in holiness, every faith has a melody."^(^41)

After this general introduction comes the application of the general Torah to the particular case of faith in the Infinite Light itself. And just as the faith in the Infinite Light itself is the supreme among faiths, so the melody belonging to this faith is the supreme among melodies:

"And that melody particular to the aforementioned faith, which is the supreme faith among all the types of wisdoms and faiths in the world, namely, faith in the Infinite Light itself that surrounds all worlds as mentioned, that melody is also above all the melodies and songs in the world that belong to every wisdom and faith."^(^42)

In the continuation of the discussion, this melody is characterized by four signs: A) It is the highest and most supreme of all melodies. B) It is the root of all of them. C) This melody is a messianic melody. D-E) This melody belongs to the supreme *zadik*. Point A we saw nearby, and here are the remaining points:

B) This supreme melody not only is it the highest among all the others in the hierarchy of melodies, but the supreme melody is also the

root and source of all the other songs that are "drawn" from it:

"And all the songs and melodies of all the wisdoms are drawn from this melody, which is above all the songs and melodies of all the wisdoms, for it is the melody belonging to the faith in the Infinite Light itself, which is above everything."^(^43)

C) The eschatological character of this supreme melody is expressed in this manner:

"And in the future to come, when He will turn to all the peoples a pure language to call all of them in the name of the Lord (Zephaniah 3:9), and all will believe in Him, may He be blessed, then^(^44) *You shall look from the head of faith* (Amana) (Song of Songs 4:8)."

Why is there a need for the expansion of the matter of melody, that every faith has one, until this law applies also to idolatrous faiths? Was it the systematic method that prefers the decisiveness of formal judgment, i.e., generality, that determined the aforementioned expansion concerning idolatrous faiths, that there too a particular melody for each and every one? Or perhaps this need was not a systematic need but specifically a concrete one: perhaps the particular case that will be discussed immediately thereafter compelled such a general formulation, since the concrete faith for which the general theory about melody and faith was prepared—this faith is an idolatrous faith?

"*From the head of faith* (rosh amana) specifically, i.e., this supreme aspect of faith as mentioned, which is the head of all faiths as mentioned. And this is *you shall look* (tashuri) specifically, i.e., the melody and song belonging to the head of this faith as mentioned."^(^45)

^(^38) Ibid.

\(^39\) In later printings 'and melody'.

\(^40\) In later printings 'their error'.

\(^41\) Ibid.

\(^42\) Ibid.

\(^43\) Ibid.

\(^44\) In later printings 'then will be fulfilled'.

\(^45\) Ibid

D) The eschatological melody belongs to the *zadik* of the generation who is of the aspect of Moses, a concept we already know from the beginning of the current Torah. The eschatological dialectic of this *zadik* is that in him is fulfilled the transformation of the silence of now into the messianic song of the future to come. This *zadik*, who is sentenced to silence now as we saw above, will himself burst forth in the messianic song in the future to come. The great silent one will be the great poet of the future to come:

"And to the aspect of the melody of this supreme faith, there is none who will merit except the *zadik* of the generation who is of the aspect of Moses, who is at the level of this faith, which is of the aspect of silence, the aspect of 'be silent, thus it arose in thought,' as mentioned. That is, it is still above speech as mentioned. For Moses is of the aspect of silence as mentioned. And this (Exodus 15:1) *Then Moses sang*. And our sages said (Sanhedrin 99b): 'It is not written *sang* (shar) but *will sing* (yashir), from here [we learn of] the resurrection of the dead from the Torah, that Moses is destined to sing also in the future to come.' For all the songs, both of this world and of the future to come, are only with Moses, who is of the aspect of silence, who merited the melody that belongs to the supreme faith above everything, in which all the songs are included, for all of them are drawn from it."(\(^46\))

E) The function of this supreme melody belonging to the great *zadik* is that he raises up and rectifies the souls that fell into the absolute heresy:

"And therefore, through the melody of the *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses as mentioned, through this all the souls that fell into this heresy of the empty space rise up and go out, for his melody is of the aspect of the head of faith, i.e., the supreme faith above everything. For through this melody and faith, all the heresy is nullified, and all the melodies are included and nullified within this melody, which is above everything, from which all the melodies are drawn as mentioned."(\(^47\))

(H)

The great question that arises with the study of this Torah revolves around the essence of faith in the Infinite Light. What is this Infinite Light? According to its definition, it 'encompasses the empty space,' or if we translate the locative definition into the language of the doctrine of paradox, then the Infinite Light is connected to the absolute difficulties that have no answer. Moreover, in accordance with the status of the melody belonging to faith in the Infinite Light, this faith is the supreme among faiths. On the other hand, we learn that the melody belonging to faith in the Infinite Light is the song that will arouse in the future to come, and the great *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses is destined to sing it in the days of the Messiah. From the combination of these things, we return and ask: What is this faith in the Infinite Light? What is the place of this faith according to its simple meaning, as per the reception of the Ari (R. Isaac Luria)? Or is it faith in one of the traditional principles of Judaism, such as Torah from Heaven, or the like? Or is it necessary to place "the faith" according to its paradoxical definition in the form of a difficulty—is faith in the Infinite Light faith in the paradox of knowledge and free will? If it is permitted to express the first impression, then this faith that is destined to be sung by the great *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses—i.e., by the Messiah Redeemer—

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is none other than of the type of the personality to whom this melody and this faith are linked for the future to come: faith in the Infinite Light is none other than faith in the great paradoxical *zadik* who is destined to be revealed in the figure of the Messiah Redeemer.

Are there proving evidences for this hypothesis that faith in the Infinite Light in Breslov doctrine is not faith in an abstract principle but

a most personal faith in the personality of the great *zadik*, i.e., R. Naḥman himself? From the outset, our hypothesis is built on the conceptual symmetry between the content of the faith and the future singer of the melody of that faith, until we came to hypothesize that the singer of the song of the faith is also the subject of that faith. One cannot expect many clear hints in this topic, which by its very nature belongs to the hidden teachings of Breslov. And nevertheless, we can support the aforementioned hypothesis with several supports that can aid our hypothesis. And if not proof for the matter, a sign for the matter: the triple equation we raised is this: Infinite Light = the great *zadik* of the aspect of Moses = the Messiah Redeemer. That is to say, hidden here is the identification of the messianic *zadik* R. Naḥman himself with light. And indeed, we find the supreme light in connection to the *zadik* or as his appellation specifically for R. Naḥman himself, and the book **Or Zoréah** (Shining Light) will prove.\(^{48}\)

In **Siaḥot HaRaN** (Conversations of R. Naḥman) you find:

"For the *zadik* inclines towards loving-kindness and judges all who dispute him favorably, that their intention is for the sake of Heaven, because the world could not bear the light of the *zadik*, for his light is very great for the world to bear it."(\(^{49}\))

It seems that R. Naḥman's words in the enigmatic teaching recorded in **Siaḥot HaRaN** that opens with the following hint to the same matter:

"Know that there is a light that shines in a thousand worlds, and this light, an ordinary person cannot receive due to its greatness, and for this a great sage is needed who can divide thousands into hundreds."(\(^{50}\))

The epithet "Light of Lights, R. Naḥman of Breslov" is most common everywhere that

Breslov Hasidim hint to their rabbi, including the title pages of their books.

I heard from S. Y. Agnon about the great enthusiasm of Breslov Hasidim on Rosh Hashanah when they reach the piyyut (liturgical poem) "Light of the world, from the treasury of life, lights from darkness He said and it was." Agnon told me that R. Abraham Hāzan <son of R. Naḥman of Tulchin> would shout the two words "Light of the world, light of the world" perhaps hundreds of times over hours before the open Holy Ark, beating his head on the Torah scrolls. Agnon was impressed that the intent was not to the Holy One, blessed be He, but to R. Naḥman.\(^51\)

\(^46\) Ibid.

\(^47\) Ibid., end of letter ט.

\(^48\) <It seems Weiss refers to the four pamphlets published in Lodz 1928–1929, edited by Simḥah Bornstein, under the title "Pamphlet Or Zoréah". These pamphlets contained innovations and explanations made by Breslov Hasidim and also printed conversations and stories from manuscript. In these pamphlets, the extreme messianic thought of Breslov Hasidim in Poland found expression, and also the first compositions of R. Abraham Hāzan were printed. See Kœnig, *Book Neveh Tzadikim*, p. 214; Assaf, *Breslov: Annotated Bibliography*, pp. 80–81, number 267.>

\(^49\) *Siaḥot HaRaN*, number 96 in its middle <Jerusalem 1979, p. 71.>

\(^50\) <Ibid., number 93, p. 67.>

And another sign for the aforementioned hypothesis can be discovered in the book **Bē'ur HaLiqquṭim** (Explanation of the Collections) by R. Abraham of Tulchin in his words on the Torah under discussion.^(^52) The explanation in this book is generally not according to the simple meaning of **Liqquṭei MoHaRaN** but is built on "combining the words of our rabbi." Nevertheless, sometimes it is possible to learn much from his words, especially when the author transmits, undoubtedly in error, some hint to a Torah not in the printed writings. It is characteristic of the conception of the Infinite Light of one of the distinguished great Breslov Hasidim that he could write words like these: "that through it [through faith] they are bound to the Infinite Light."^(^53) This personal expression of binding (*hitqashrut*) parallels the Breslov demand of "binding to the true *zadik*," and supports the hypothesis expressed above that the Infinite Light is nothing but an appellation for the true *zadik*, i.e., R. Naḥman.^(^54)

To this connection likely belong R. Naḥman's expressions, "What he said, that my fire will burn forever, will not be extinguished, and he said in Yiddish in this language: **Mein Feuerl wet shoyt toln biz Moshiach wet kumen**"^(^55); or a seemingly impersonal formulation of that same saying: "There is one whose lamp will not be extinguished forever."^(^56) The Yiddish formulation, despite the mention of the name Messiah, is less prominent in its messianic claim than the Hebrew formulation built openly on the blessing of the Haftarah said about David: "And his lamp will not be extinguished forever and ever." This saying, originally applied to King David, was applied by R. Naḥman to himself, and here is nothing but one of the prominent cases of his identification with King David, and an indirect messianic claim, clear in the Hebrew formulation and concealed in the Yiddish one. The conceptual background of this image is apparently different from the entire matter of identifying R. Naḥman with light, great light, light of lights, and in the terminology of

Lurianic Kabbalah—Infinite Light. Besides the difference between lamp and light—it's all the same. It seems that R. Naḥman does not identify himself with the lamp, but the image hovering before us in the aforementioned expressions is this: he holds the lamp in his hand, and he is not the lamp itself. The conceptual background for the brief expressions you find in **Liqquṭei MoHaRaN** I, number 275:

"Know that from every commandment that is performed, one lamp is made from it, and when a person passes away, if it is a great soul that is very precious in the eyes of the Holy One, blessed be He, then they are given to be one who searches in the treasures of the King (*Ganzei de-Malka*), that he searches and takes for himself what he wants from the treasures of the King, may He be blessed, and this is the ultimate of all the pleasures of the World to Come. And for the search, lamps are needed [...] and with these lamps the soul searches after the passing away in the treasures of the King [...] but there is a *zadik* who mortifies himself in his lifetime, and even while still alive he searches in the treasures of his Father."^(^57)

The special dialectic between the relations of lamp and light finds expression in R. Naḥman's words of hint on the tale of the exchanged children (which was not printed in Horodetzky's edition and the other "modern" editions for literary purposes only and was printed in the Hasidic editions after tale 11: "Tale of a Prince and a Handmaid's Son who were Exchanged"). There (beginning "And the words") it is said:

"And the moon was holding a lamp in her hand, and when day arrives, then the lamp does not give light, for a lamp in daylight etc., and this is what she said, the night to the day: Why is it that when you come I have no name (as explained above)? For in daytime the lamp is of no use at all."^(^58)

The moon is the tenth sefirah, Malkhut (Kingship), and in Breslov Hasidism a symbol of the *zadik*-Messiah in his poverty and lack of light, and this is not the place to enter the details of the symbolism. In any case, the moon is a self-symbol of R. Naḥman, and you find it explicitly "holding a lamp in her hand," similar to Torah 275 above about the *zadik* who searches in the treasures of the King. (^59) In any case, it is clear that the matter of the lamp and the matter of light in Breslov symbolism are not equal, and therefore the famous saying about the lamp does not belong to this context.

(^51) <On the intense messianism in the thought of R. Abraham Ḥazan of Tulchin, an important Breslov Hasid in Jerusalem (died 1918 in Uman), and the significance he gave to R. Naḥman's place in the redemption process, see throughout his book **Kokhavei Or**, Jerusalem 1987; and book **Bē'ur HaLiqquṭim**, Jerusalem 1935. See also H. Zeitlin's note, **The Light of the Messiah in Breslov Doctrine**, Warsaw 1936, p. 5; the words of M. Piekarz, "The Breslov Interpretation of the Tales," **Breslov Hasidism: Chapters in the Life of Its Founder, Its Writings, and Its Offshoots**, second expanded edition, Jerusalem 1996, pp. 136–139; and the background to this messianism, Y. Meir, "'The Hasidism of the Future to Come': Neo-Romanticism, Hasidism, and Messianic Longings in the Writings of Hillel Zeitlin," in: H. Zeitlin, **Rabbi Naḥman of Breslov, the Sorrow of the World and Messianic Longings**, prepared for press and added introduction and notes by Y. Meir, **Yeriot**, 5, edited by G. Ofrat, A. Reiner, Y. Ta-Shma, Jerusalem 2005 [in press]. More on Ḥazan, see N. Anshin, "R. Abraham son of R. Naḥman, of blessed memory," **Mevo'ei HaNaḥal**, year 3, collection 36 (1981), pp. 29–37; collection 37 (1981), pp. 24–31. This blurring between God and R. Naḥman appears in several later Breslov writings, see for example R. Yitzḥak Breiter, "Divisions of the Stream," **Pamphlet Or*

*HaZoréah**, pamphlet 2 (Marcheshvan 1929), seventh page, letter ט, pp. 31–32 [printed again in several places, see among others: R. Shmuel (Czaczkas) Breslover, **Book Yesod Tzadik**, Jerusalem 1958, pp. 57–59; idem, **Book Meshekh HaNaḥal**, Jerusalem 1964, pp. 49–50]. On this blurring in a slightly different manner, see R. Shmuel Horowitz, **Pamphlet Hitqashrut LaTzadik HaEmet**, [Jerusalem 1999], pp. 25–27.>

(^52) R. Abraham Ḥazan, **Book Bē'ur HaLiqquṭim**, which is to explain and interpret with wonderful and awesome profundity the wonderful teachings found in the book **Liqquṭei MoHaRaN**, Jerusalem 1935, 88b–91b <The book in this edition was given to print by R. Shmuel Horowitz, see Kœnig, **Book Neveh Tzadikim**, p. 181; Assaf, **Breslov: Annotated Bibliography**, p. 26 number 39. See also: **Book Bē'ur HaLiqquṭim**, and now republished corrected and completed by Breslov Hasidim, Jerusalem 1989, the discussion on Torah 64 appears on pp. 242–248. To this edition the hidden editors prefaced a broad introduction on the essence of the book and its author, pp. 1–41.>

(^53) R. Abraham Ḥazan, **Book Bē'ur HaLiqquṭim**, 90a <and in the new edition, p. 245.>

(^54) <On the terms "Hidden Light" and "Faith in the Infinite Light," see also Weiss, "A Secret Scroll on the Order of the Coming of the Messiah," **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, pp. 190–191; there, note 6, Weiss notes that in the first version of Torah 64, the manuscript version, the matter of "faith in the Infinite Light" does not appear.>

(^55) **Ḥayyei MoHaRaN**, I, "Conversations Relating to the Teachings," letter טו <Jerusalem 1985, p. 44.> And again there at the end of part I with a slight change in Yiddish spelling <ibid., "His Journey and Sojourn in Uman," number 229, p. 247.>

(^56) **Siaḥot HaRaN**, number 134, <p. 91: [...] that he said there is one whose lamp cannot burn except for some hour, he searches with the lamp that hour that it burns. And afterwards the lamp is consumed and he has nothing with

which to search. And there is one whose lamp burns some hours more and can search more but afterwards it goes out. And there is one whose lamp burns one day. And there is one that burns even more and more. But there is one who has many wondrous lamps like these that burn and shine forever and ever and are not extinguished forever. And he merits to search in the treasures of the King always for eternal eternities and everlasting ever. Happy is he.>

\(^57\) <*Liqqūtei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 275.>

\(^58\) <"Tale of a Prince and a Handmaid's Son who were Exchanged," *Book Sippurei Ma'asiyot*, tale 11, p. 171. On Weiss's interpretation of this tale, see "Studies in the Self-Perception of R. Naḥman," *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 158–170.>

(I)

The term "Infinite Light" itself appears in one of the most complicated teachings we have formulated by R. Naḥman himself. I refer to Torah number 24 in *Liqqutei MoHaRaN* I, called according to its beginning "The Middle of the World" (Aziluta de-ʿAlma). This Torah is among the most difficult and hidden in *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, and all of it speaks of the zādik as I will try to show below. I cannot enter into an analysis of the entire Torah here but will suffice to bring what seems to me to prove the equation Infinite Light = the true zādik, R. Naḥman himself. And this is the opening of the Torah, after bringing words from the Zohar from "Saba de-Mishpatim":

"Know that there is a light that is above souls, spirits, and higher souls (nefashin, ruḥin, neshamot), and it is the Infinite Light. And even though the intellect does not grasp it, nevertheless the pursuit of thought pursues after it, and through the pursuit, then the intellect grasps it, in the aspect of 'reaches and does not reach' (mattei ve-lo mattei), for in truth it is impossible to grasp it, for it is above nefesh, ruḥ, neshamah."(^60\)

At the end of the Torah are some hints as to where the pole of the intent of the words lies:

"And this is what the elders of the study hall asked: 'Where is the middle of the world?' He raised his finger and said: 'Here.' They said to him: 'Who says so?' He said to them: 'Come and measure.' That they asked him: How is the Infinite Light grasped, which is the middle of the world, from which all draw vitality and abundance? 'He raised his finger,' this is the aspect of blessings as mentioned, the aspect of *And Aaron lifted his hands and blessed* as mentioned, that is, through the blessings the minds are pounded in Keter (Crown) and become palaces as mentioned. 'And they said to him: Who says so,' who is this who will enter the palaces of transformations, to the place of the 'shells,' to raise up from there the

holiness in the aspect of incense as mentioned, and through his raising up the blessings will be elevated as mentioned. And this 'Who says so' (מי ימר) is language of transformation (temurah), language of (Leviticus 27:33) *if he shall at all change it.*"(^61\)

The most important point of grasp in this discussion on the nature of the Infinite Light is found in the identification between the Infinite Light and the middle of the world "from which all draw vitality and abundance." "The middle of the world" in the Zohar is nothing but an appellation for the last sefirah, which is called also "the Land of Israel": "The holy land is the middle of the world. And in the middle of the holy land is Jerusalem"; and so you find: (^62\)

(^59\)

The expression "searches in the treasures of the King" is found in the writings of Nathan of Gaza, see G. Scholem, *Be-ʿIqvot Mashiah*, Jerusalem 1942 <p. 102: "And likewise the soul of King Messiah who is bound to the Tree of Life rules over all the treasures of his Father, performs rectifications in all aspects and realities, the prohibitions of forbidden and permitted, impurity and purity do not apply to him, he can turn evil to good." [See further Abraham Elqayam, "The Secret of Faith in the Writings of Nathan of Gaza," doctoral dissertation, The Hebrew University of Jerusalem, 1994, pp. 210–220]. It is not an identical phrase but similar. This expression recurs in *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, II, Torah 5, number 15; in *Siaḥot HaRaN*, number 134, p. 91; and throughout the Breslov song about R. Naḥman and his disciple R. Nathan, by Yechiel Menachem Mendel of Medvedevke, *Shir Yedidut*, Jerusalem 1907. See also the words of R. Naḥman of Tsherin, *Book Qedushat Shabbat*, Jerusalem 1968, 5a.>

(^60\)

<*Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 24, letter נ.>

(^61\)

<Ibid., letter נ.>

identifications between *zadik* and Infinite Light is almost closed.

"The dominion of the secret of faith is within the middle of the point of the entire world, the holy land, in the Holy of Holies. And even though now it is not in its fullness, by its merit the entire world is sustained, and nourishment and provision go out from there to everything in every place, the side of settlement. And because of this, even though Israel is now outside the holy land, with all that, from the power and merit of the land, nourishment and provision are found for the entire world. And about this it is written (Deuteronomy 8:10) *And you shall bless the Lord your God for the good land which He has given you.*"^(^63\)

This passage is almost parallel in parallelism to what is said in Torah 24: "from which [from the middle of the world] all draw vitality and abundance," except that in Breslov words, apparently the abundance and vitality have a more spiritual meaning. Be that as it may, "the middle of the world" in the Zohar hints unequivocally to the last sefirah, which is Malkhut (Kingship), of which both the Land of Israel and Jerusalem are appellations.^(^64\)

In Breslov, the last sefirah became a symbol for the true *zadik* in every place.^(^65\)

Hear from this that the middle of the world is nothing but the great *zadik*, and if so also the Infinite Light, which is the middle of the world according to the explicit words of the text in the Torah under discussion—this Infinite Light is nothing but the *zadik*. Additional evidence for the personal conception of the Infinite Light in Torah 24 can serve the grammatical form of the sentence formulation: "Who is this who will enter the palaces of transformations to the place of the 'shells'?" although we have no certainty that the subject here too is the Infinite Light mentioned a few lines earlier. In any case, the chain of

^(^62\) Zohar, II, 157a.

^(^63\) Ibid., 157b.

^(^64\) <See on this also M. Idel, "On the Land of Israel in Jewish Mystical Thought of the Middle Ages," *The Land of Israel in Jewish Thought in the Middle Ages*, edited by M. Hallamish, A. Ravitzky, Jerusalem 1991, pp. 193–214; B. Zack, "Land and the Land of Israel in the Zohar," *The Book of Zohar and Its Generation (Jerusalem Studies in Jewish Thought* 8), edited by J. Dan, Jerusalem 1989, pp. 239–253.>

^(^65\) <Here Weiss intended to list several examples for the matter.>

(J)

It is possible to contemplate the entire episode of the identification of the middle of the world, which is the Infinite Light, also from another side. It is known that the Foundation Stone (Even HaShetiyah), from which was the beginning of creation according to the sources of our traditional literature, is also one of the appellations of the last sefirah in Kabbalah. If in Breslov doctrine the true *zadik* is of the aspect of the last sefirah, then it is no wonder that also the "Foundation Stone" appears in this meaning.\(^66\)

\(^66\)

<On this or on the previous note (the matter is not clear from the manuscript), Weiss wrote: 'Not clear what I wanted to write here.' On 'Foundation Stone' as an appellation for R. Naḥman, see further Weiss, "The Attractive Power of the Boundary," **Studies in Breslav Hasidism**, p. 108: "Among the great symbols that R. Naḥman mobilized to express the essence of himself, we find the legendary concept of the Foundation Stone. This is the stone that according to traditional literature 'from it the world was founded.' The Foundation Stone is the stone upon which the Temple was built and its place was in the Holy of Holies and the Ark rested upon it. In the mystical literature of the Zohar, the Foundation Stone was accepted as an appellation for the last sefirah. Through R. Naḥman's identification with this tenth sefirah, the way was opened for affiliated symbolism. R. Naḥman is not only the navel of the world, but he receives the special characteristics of the last sefirah, that sefirah full of dramatic fluctuations in which R. Naḥman found the mirror image for his soul and the many upheavals in his soul's life. And another aspect was added to this last sefirah in R. Naḥman's self-reflection: and it is the aspect of kingship of this sefirah in the messianic sense. The eschatological significance of the last sefirah is an important achievement in Breslov doctrine:

this is an aspect not found in the accepted systems of Jewish mysticism, and it is the executive instrument of the restorative enterprise in Breslov." See also idem, "Studies in the Self-Perception of R. Naḥman," *ibid.*, p. 165; J. Weiss, 'Sense and Nonsense in Defining Judaism: The Strange Case of Nahman of Brazlav', **Studies in East European Jewish Mysticism and Hasidism**, ed. D. Goldstein, London, Portland 1997, p. 253. For an extreme expression of this position, see R. Yisrael Dov Odesser, **Book Yisrael Saba**, Jerusalem [2005], pp. 215–217. See also the words of Abraham Breslover (Czaczkes), **Book Or Olam**, Jerusalem 1972, pp. 74–114, comparing the 'holiness of the *zadik*' (R. Naḥman) to the Temple, that 'they are two friends that are not separated', and among these he also speaks of the 'Foundation Stone'. The term 'Foundation Stone' in time became one of the appellations of R. Naḥman's burial place, 'the holy tomb' in Uman, with its users blurring the separation between the term's belonging to a person and its belonging to a place, see for example the words of R. Naḥman of Tsherin, **Book Parperaot LeḤokhmah**, Jerusalem 1972, 34b. One of the later Breslov publications dealing with the 'tomb' is also called **Even HaShetiyah** [HaShM"D].>

(K)

We now reach the climax of the entire Torah "Come unto Pharaoh." What is the faith in the Infinite Light, whose meaning, as per the feet for this hypothesis, is faith in the *zadik*? What is the content of paradoxical faith in the *zadik*? Is it possible to discover any hint of content to this faith? If we scrutinize the language of the Torah, then near the end of the Torah clear hints can be discovered to the secret of the essence of this faith, which is nothing but the doctrine of the *zadik*'s incarnation (*hithalbashut*). The other version in the manuscript, mentioned at the beginning of our chapter, contains these hints scattered throughout the entire Torah, whereas in the printed version these hints are concentrated for the doctrine of incarnation into the last section of the Torah.

What is said in the manuscript version in hints that were removed from the printed version in the process of editing and developing the Torah? The most prominent point in formulating the process of the formation of the worlds in the manuscript version is this: in describing the events of the contraction of the light and the formation of the empty space, R. Nahman follows Lurianic Kabbalah as these events were described in **Etz Hayyim** and in many pamphlets.

"When His simple will arose to create the worlds in order to bestow goodness to His other, because His attribute is to bestow goodness, and His light was extending infinitely, and He contracted His light to the sides, and an empty space remained, and within the empty space He created all the worlds through His speech and His wisdom."^(^67)

This is essentially the original conception of Lurianic Kabbalah, in which the contraction of the light to the sides and the formation of an empty space following this contraction assume

the spatial possibility for the formation of the worlds within this space that has no divinity.

Nearby, the role of the contraction is defined differently. Its role is not creating the spatial possibility for worlds to be created within it, but the distinct articulation of the divine attributes:

"And before creation, the Blessed Name had all the attributes, whether compassion or wisdom, but they were in the aspect of infinity, for they were not limited, and through the contraction He afterwards made a boundary for all the attributes, until we human beings can discern the attribute of His goodness and compassion. And the discernment is from the intellect and wisdom that He limited in us and built the worlds."^(^68)

The interpretation of the verse "For I have hardened" advances the revelation of the secret concealed here somewhat:

"For I have hardened"—language of clothing and concealment. 'His heart and the heart of his servants, so that I may set these signs of Mine in his midst,' i.e., that the Holy One, blessed be He, concealed and contracted His divinity, the Infinite Light, to the sides in order to create the entire creation."^(^69)

Here we find not only the definition of the Infinite Light as divinity, but—and this is the main point of our interest in the manuscript version—the language of clothing (*לבוש*) as a synonym for the language of concealment in describing the contraction. Already the language of concealment is not fitting to the spirit of original Lurianic Kabbalah, but we find in Hasidism that the contraction is understood as the concealment of the divine light within creation.^(^70) However, we have not seen the language of "clothing" in connection to contraction. The intent seemingly is that concealment is clothing, that is: the divinity did not withdraw completely from the empty space as in the original

conception of Lurianic Kabbalah, but only concealed itself—or: clothed itself there. Except that this is precisely the weak point: the yes and no contradict each other—their contradiction is truth, and nevertheless yes and no are both truth:

"And Pharaoh is the aspect of the contraction and the empty space, and 'heart' (לב) this is the aspect of the interior (תוך) of the wisdom. And the contraction was also in the wisdom, but it is impossible to understand how He removed from there the light of His wisdom so that it would not be in the aspect of infinity—is not the contraction also through His wisdom? Hence there is no empty space from His wisdom here. And this: 'For I have hardened,' i.e., I clothed and concealed the interior and heart of the empty space of the wisdoms mentioned, and I clothed and concealed the interior and heart of their premises, so that no person can understand this. And this that no person can understand this empty space—all this is so that within it I will place within it all the worlds." (^71\)

The interpretation on these verses is very complicated because it is built on concepts that are not in the manuscript version; in any case, the printed version does not know the language of clothing in interpreting these verses. And furthermore, the strange usage of the word "interior" (תוך) in connection to languages of contraction arouses attention in the manuscript version. This strange usage is not in the printed **Liqqutei MoHaRaN**, just as all languages of clothing are lacking there in this passage. Still, what is the matter of this "interior"? "And Pharaoh is the aspect of contraction and the empty space and 'heart' this is the aspect of the interior of the wisdom and the contraction," and further: "I clothed and concealed its heart, the interior of the empty space of the wisdoms mentioned, and I clothed and concealed the interior and heart of their premises." What is the interior of the contraction, of the empty space, or of the wisdom of the contraction and

empty space? "Interior" means "inside" or "secret."

(^67\) <**Liqqutei MoHaRaN**, I, Torah 64, manuscript version.>

(^68\) <Ibid.>

(^69\) <Ibid.>

(^70\) See for the time being M. Teitelbaum, **The Rabbi of Liadi and the Habad Faction**, part 2, Warsaw 1913, pp. 43–94> The conception of contraction in Hasidism requires detailed analysis anew. See now T. Ross, "Two Interpretations of the Doctrine of Contraction: R. Hayyim of Volozhin and R. Shneur Zalman of Liadi," **Jerusalem Studies in Jewish Thought** 2 (1982), pp. 153–169; M. Idel, "On the History of the Concept 'Contraction' in Kabbalah and Research," **Jerusalem Studies in Jewish Thought** 10 (1992), pp. 59–112; idem, **Hasidism: Between Ecstasy and Magic**, Jerusalem and Tel Aviv 2001, pp. 164–174; R. Elier, **The Doctrine of the Unity of Opposites: The Mystical Theosophy of Habad**, Jerusalem 1993, pp. 79–89.>

(^71\) <**Liqqutei MoHaRaN**, I, Torah 64, manuscript version.>

Torah number 64 in *Liqqutei MoHaRaN* I describes the dialectical structure of the world, a structure that became unique to reality in the initial movement of the creation of the world. The empty space—Lurianic Kabbalah grants it the meaning of the spatial possibility of the world. It came into being as a result of the tragic event of the contraction (*zimzum*), i.e., the act in which God contracted and withdrew His divinity that previously filled everything. Contraction and empty space, then, descended bound to each other in conceptual necessity. Contraction is a flaw, and according to Breslov doctrine, which transforms the ontological concepts of Lurianic Kabbalah into logical concepts, this flaw has a logical character. This contraction, belonging essentially to the empty space, is not only the spatial possibility of the world but also its logical possibility. The price that must be paid for the formation of the world can be determined in the doctrine of the fundamental contradiction upon which everything is built, the contradiction of "is" and "is not" of God. In the act of contraction, the metaphysical contradiction was revealed that there is God within the worlds and yet He is not there. This is the fundamental contradiction of the world, and R. Nahman expounds on the weight of this supreme contradiction, upon which the entire dialectical structure of the world is built.

In the next step of this Torah, R. Nahman distinguishes between "two types of denial of the living God." (^72\) One type of denial originates in external wisdoms. R. Nahman is convinced that denial of this type is not, in an ultimate sense, dangerous. The denial caused by external wisdoms does not stem from the empty space but from another, second tragic act that Lurianic Kabbalah uses in explaining the formation of the world, namely, the breaking of the vessels (*shevirat ha-kelim*). Also, this Lurianic concept became transformed in Breslov doctrine and became a logical concept. The difficulties, i.e., the

contradictions belonging to the act of the breaking of the vessels, are not absolute contradictions. Certainly, a person misled among them must strive to flee and escape from the dizzying realm of these difficulties. The main character of these lower difficulties is that in principle they can be resolved. This is the realm of our sages' saying: "Know what to answer a heretic." For at the time of the breaking of the vessels, sparks of holiness and broken letters fell, and these letters of the breaking of the vessels still constitute the last residue of rationality ruling in the realm of the breaking of the vessels. Therefore, it is possible to determine that the difficulties formed from the encounter between religion and the sciences are not absolute and can be resolved through the rational residue of their place of formation. Not so the previous type of difficulties, those stemming from the empty space, to which R. Nahman devotes all the fervor of his interest. In the realm of these difficulties, it is not external science that encounters the demand of religion, but if it is possible to say so, religion itself contradicts itself there. One religious demand pushes aside another religious demand. A religious demand is that there be no divinity within the worlds, for only in this way can the danger of pantheistic theology be prevented. And yet another religious demand presses its sister and demands the existence of divinity within the worlds despite everything. This contradiction, which is the contraction of the empty space, is the desperate contradiction of the world's structure. How is it possible that there is no God within the worlds and yet there is? This is the point of ignition of Torah 64 that we stand in analyzing.

Any rational effort will not succeed in this realm of difficulties from the aspect of the empty space, whose prototype we recognized in the formulation above: the supreme contradiction representing the absolute type of contradictions is not the question of whether there is God or not—this question belongs to the non-absolute type, for it arises from the

power of those external wisdoms. I do not mean to say that this problem did not occupy R. Naḥman. In one of the tales, in "The Tale of the Wise Man and the Simple Man,"^(^73\) R. Naḥman described the figure of the wise man in shocking colors. This wise man studied philosophy and the science of medicine, two sciences that represent the external wisdoms that bring the wise man—in the aforementioned tale—not only to extreme despair and extreme loneliness but also to denial of the existence of a king over the country. This allegorical expression of the nature of the denial leaves no doubt that the denial of the existence of God holds a significant place among the religious struggles that find expression in Breslov doctrine. However, in Torah 64, the problem of the existence of God is not grasped as a supreme problem. The supreme problem is the existence of God or His non-existence specifically within the world, which is a completely different question and, according to Breslov's own definition, draws not from external sources but from the internal sources of religion itself. In this realm, there is no place for attempts of rationalism; only paradoxical faith is likely to overcome the internal contradiction coming from the empty space, formulated in its supreme formulation in the two religious demands that contradict each other, namely: A) There is no God within the worlds. B) There is and there is. In an unexpected interpretation of the name of the people of Israel as "Hebrew" ('Ivri), R. Naḥman demonstrates his doctrine on paradoxical faith, through which Israel "cross over" ('ovrim), i.e., overcome the aforementioned supreme contradiction.

"For there is no answer at all to this denial, since it comes from the empty space, from where He contracted His divinity, as it were. Only Israel, through faith, cross over all the wisdoms and even over this heresy (apikorsut)\^(^74\) that comes from the empty space, for they believe in the Blessed Name without any investigation and wisdom, only with complete faith, that the Blessed Name fills all worlds and

surrounds all worlds. Hence, He is, as it were, within all the worlds and around all the worlds. And there needs to be a distinction, as it were, between the filling and the surrounding, for if not, then everything is one."^(^75\)

The denial for which there is no answer except through paradoxical faith alone—one must "flee and escape from there, not to study and look at their words at all, because, God forbid, he will certainly sink there, for about him it is said: *All who come to her shall not return* etc."^(^76\)

The question standing before us here is to determine the concrete content of the supreme contradiction in the empty space. From R. Naḥman's formulation, it is clear that the reference is not to the contradiction itself of the existence of God within the world or His non-existence in general, but to specific writings in which this problem finds defined expression. The fact that the reference is to specific writings emerges clearly from his words "not to study and look at their words at all." What are the heretical writings whose pole revolves around this theological problem, and from which one must flee and escape without studying them? I propose, as a working hypothesis, that these heretical writings to which R. Naḥman hints are none other than the writings of extreme Sabbatean theology, teaching the doctrine of the incarnation of God in the messianic king. This heretical doctrine fulfills the aforementioned definition, i.e., non-existence of God within the world and His existence within it despite everything.

Were these heretical writings known to R. Naḥman of Breslov? As long as this fact is not proven from other sources, it will be only a campaign in need of proof from the Torah we are analyzing, which determines according to the pole of my interpretation that R. Naḥman himself engaged in those heretical writings:

"But know, if there is a great ṣadik who is of the aspect of Moses, he specifically needs to

study these heretical matters. And even though it is impossible to resolve them as mentioned, nonetheless, through his study that he studies there, he raises up from there several souls that fell and sank into this heresy."(^77\)

The heresy of the empty space concerning the existence of God within the world and His non-existence there is not a passing and transient thought of denial in the mind, but a historical heresy that claimed victims in the history of Israel's faith and was formulated in writings. The role of the supreme *zadik*, who is R. Naḥman himself, is to rectify the victims of this heresy in a paradoxical manner by reading the books of that very heresy. Here we have a new variation on the Hasidic Torah of the descent of the *zadik* for the purpose of raising up and rectification. (^78\)

However, there is here an unexpected turn regarding the customary formulations of the idea of the *zadik*'s descent. The innovation that R. Naḥman innovated in the history of the doctrine of the *zadik*'s descent rectifies through his descent not human beings sunk in transgressions, but human beings sunk in heresy. And it is possible to add and say, in a defined and specific heresy, that built on the problem of the existence of God within the world and His non-existence there—the problem of late Sabbateanism and Frankism. Hence we learn that R. Naḥman saw it as an obligation upon himself to study Sabbatean heretical writings. (^79\)

Our interpretation will gain strength and vigor if indeed we can prove that R. Naḥman's study of Sabbatean writings left its traces in his own doctrine. (^80\)

(^72\)

Thus the version in the first printing, and in later printings it was corrected: "two types of heresy (*apikorsut*)". Every time "denial of the living God" is mentioned in the first printing, it was corrected thus in later printings, and likewise everywhere "denier of the living God" is mentioned. Expressions that seemed too explicit and extreme. On the

different versions of Torah 64, see in the previous essay, note 1.>

(^73\)

<"The Tale of the Wise Man and the Simple Man," tale 9, *Book Sippurei Ma'asiyot*, published by Agudat Meshekh HaNaḥal, Jerusalem 1985, pp. 78–106. I analyzed several aspects of this tale in my essay "Studies in the Self-Perception of R. Naḥman of Breslov," *Tarbiz* 27 (1958), pp. 358–371. As reprinted in: J. Weiss, *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, edited by M. Piekartz, Jerusalem 1975, pp. 150–171.>

(^74\)

Also in the first printing thus.

(^75\)

Liqqutei MoHaRaN, I, Torah 64, letter ב.

(^76\)

Ibid., end of letter ב.

(^77\)

Ibid., letter ג.

(^78\)

See analysis of this idea in my essay: "The Beginning of the Growth of the Hasidic Path," *Zion* 16 (1951), pp. 46–105 <reprinted in the collection: *Chapters in the Doctrine of Hasidism and its History*, edited by A. Rubinstein, Jerusalem 1978, pp. 122–181.>

(^79\)

<Weiss hinted at this matter also in two essays printed from his estate, "First Life Stations and the Beginning of the Controversy," *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, p. 25; "Burning of Skins for the Purpose of Covering," *ibid.*, pp. 244–248.>

Below, R. Naḥman defines the realms of the two types of denial he spoke of above with a new definition. The realm of non-absolute denial, that which can be resolved with answers, is the realm of speech. Indeed, R. Naḥman comes to prove the speech-character of this realm of problematics from the aspect of the creation of the worlds through speech, the aspect of "By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, and by the breath of His mouth all their host." And apparently the matter should be understood thus, that the possibility of speech in the answer to the difficulty is founded in the speech-act of creation, from whence these difficulties and denials stem and descend.

Not so the realm of supreme problematics, that of the empty space, which is the problem formulated as the supreme heresy of the existence of God within the world and His non-existence there. This is the realm of absolute silence, the acoustic parallel to the absolute logical paradox. That is, the muteness of the empty space is the acoustic correspondence to the logical paradox. From there, no speech, no wisdom, and no intellect, only silence. Therefore also from the human side, no efforts of answer and resolution of the difficulties move there; rather, the acoustic value of the supreme paradox prevails also from the human side: silence.

\(^80\) <See on this further J. Weiss, 'Sense and Nonsense in Defining Judaism: The Strange Case of Nahman of Brazlav', **Studies in East European Jewish Mysticism and Hasidism**, ed. D. Goldstein, London and Portland 1997, pp. 249–269; N. Zadoff and Y. Meir, "'Possibility of Frankist Hints in the Teaching of R. Naḥman of Breslov": Three Hidden Passages from the Joseph Weiss Archive," **A Book Marking Twenty Years Since the Death of Gershom Scholem (Jerusalem Studies in Jewish Thought* 20)*, edited by J. Dan, Jerusalem 2004 [in print]. Additional essays by

Weiss on this subject remained hidden and are in various stages of preparation for print. On similar possibilities wrote also Y. Liebes, "The General Rectification of R. Naḥman of Breslov and its Relation to Sabbateanism," **Zion** 45 (1980), pp. 201–245 (reprinted in: idem, **The Secret of the Sabbatean Faith: A Collection of Essays**, Jerusalem 1995, pp. 238–261). See the responses to this essay: A. Rapoport-Albert, **Zion** 46 (1981), pp. 346–351 (and Liebes's response, *ibid.*, pp. 352–355); Y. Mondshine, **Zion** 47 (1982), pp. 198–223 (and Liebes's response, *ibid.*, pp. 224–231); and the words of Arthur Green on the controversy surrounding R. Naḥman, A. Y. Green, **Tormented Master: A Life of Rabbi Nahman of Bratslav**, Tel Aviv 1990, pp. 106–107, 395–397 note 26, and further according to the index. Joseph Dan raised in several places the connection between R. Naḥman and Sabbateanism in the conception of the *zadik*, see for example Y. Dan, **Modern Jewish Messianism**, Tel Aviv 1998, pp. 184–186; idem, **Apocalypse Then and Now**, Tel Aviv 2000, pp. 309–311; idem, "The Dual Face of Messianism in Hasidism," **In the Circles of Hasidim: A Collection of Studies in Memory of Professor Mordecai Wilensky**, edited by I. Etkes, D. Assaf, Y. Bartal, A. Reiner, Jerusalem 2000, pp. 310–311; J. Dan, 'The Two Meanings of Hasidic Messianism', **Hesed Ve-Emet: Studies in Honor of Ernest S. Frerichs**, ed. J. Magness, S. Gitin, Atlanta 1998, pp. 399–401; *ibid.*, "Rabbi Nahman's Third Begger", **History and Literature: New Readings of Jewish Texts in Honor of Arnold J. Band**, ed. W. Cutter, D. C. Jacobson, Providence 2002, pp. 51–52. See also Dan's critique of Green: *ibid.*, 'Green's Tormented Master', **The Jewish Quarterly Review** 74 (1984), p. 335. On attempts to minimize this element found in R. Naḥman's doctrine to the point of canceling it, as well as expropriating it as one of the arguments used by the opponents of Breslov Hasidism, see Ch. Mark, "Why Did Rabbi Moshe Tzvi of Savran Pursue R. Nathan of Nemirov and Breslov Hasidim?" **Zion** 69 (2004), pp. 487–500; idem, "The Tale of the Breastplate and the

Rectification of the Night Incident: From the Archives of Breslov Censorship," **Zion** 70 (2005), pp. 191–216. Mark concludes and says: "It is therefore possible to determine with a great degree of certainty that Sabbateanism did not occupy a central place in R. Naḥman's world, and the esoteric layers of his work do not deal with Sabbateanism and Frankism," *ibid.*, p. 211. Weiss's analysis thus presents a different reading of the sources, a reading that responds to R. Naḥman's hints and does not relate only to the overt aspect of his teachings. Also, it should be emphasized that several episodes and journeys in R. Naḥman's life are explained only in the context of the messianic-Sabbatean rectification, but this is not the place to elaborate.>

That is to say, silence and faith are nothing but one thing. Paradoxical faith—its only articulation is the gnashing of teeth of the silent believer.

"But in the empty space, which encompasses all the worlds as mentioned, and it is empty of everything, as it were, as mentioned, there is no speech there at all, and not even intellect without letters as mentioned. And therefore the perplexities that come from there are of the aspect of silence."^(^81\)

And the famous saying of the Talmud in Menahot (page 29b) is brought as proof for the matter, where Moses asks about the paradox of R. Akiva's death, and they answer him:

"They answered him: 'Be silent, thus it arose in thought.' That is, you must be silent and not ask an answer and resolution for this difficulty. For thus it arose in thought, which is above speech; therefore you must be silent about this question, because it is of the aspect 'arose in thought,' where there is no speech to resolve it. And similarly, those difficulties and perplexities that come from the empty space, where there is no speech nor intellect as mentioned, therefore they are of the aspect of silence, and one must only believe and be silent there."^(^82\)

The religious obligation of silence—where the hand of answer does not reach—rises and peeks also in another place in Breslov doctrine. It appears as an answer on R. Naḥman's lips in the face of the accusations of those who dispute him. In the tale of the Seven Beggars, in the story of the fifth day, these words are found:

"And one said that his silence is the aspect of 'the little that holds much,' for there are many accusers against him and many slanderers who inform against him very much, and all that they inform and speak and accuse against him with much slander, he, through his silence, resolves everything through the fact that he is merely

silent (for he does only some silence and it is a resolution for everything). Hence, his silence is the little that holds much."^(^83\)

Hence, silence is found as the only weapon fitting the intensity of the accusations of those who dispute R. Naḥman. If we wish to uphold the concept of silence in its precise metaphysical severity as it emerged from the Torah we are analyzing, then we will need to say that the character of the accusers' accusations is such that there is a connection between the difficulties that the accusers pose against R. Naḥman and the root problem of the empty space. We must return to a more precise clarification of the nature of the controversy against R. Naḥman in another connection. For now, suffice it to hint that the part of "The Tale of the Seven Beggars" in which R. Naḥman depicted his position of silence in the face of the accusations of those who dispute him was told out of a Sabbatean or Frankist connection, and already R. Nathan stood on this fact as belonging to the matter. These are the words of R. Nathan concerning the occasion when R. Naḥman told the discussed passage of "The Tale of the Seven Beggars," which, as is known, was told part by part over several days.^(^84\) And these are the words of R. Nathan:

"The tale of the Seven Beggars that is printed in the Book of Tales was told over several days, and each time he told a matter belonging to that about which they told him, that through this he began to tell the tale."^(^85\)

^(^81\) *Liqqūtei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter א.

^(^82\) Ibid.

^(^83\) *Sippurei Ma'asiyot le-Rabi Naḥman mi-Breslev*, with introduction by S. A. Horodetzky, Berlin 1922, p. 161, tale of the fifth day <Jerusalem 1985 edition, p. 269–270.>

\(^84\) See *Siahot HaRaN*, numbers 149–151 <Jerusalem 1979, pp. 102–106>; and in *Hayyei MoHaRaN*, I, "Conversations Relating to the Tales," <letters ה-ז, numbers 63–64, Jerusalem 1985, pp. 62–63. On Weiss's method in interpreting the tale, see also N. Zadoff and Y. Meir, "'I Prefer to Be Esoteric': Joseph Weiss and the Tale of the Seven Beggars," *Haaretz*, Culture and Literature, Eve of Shavuot (5.6.2003), p. 2.>

\(^85\) *Siahot HaRaN*, number 149, <p. 102.>

R. Nathan gives a precise description of the different circumstances in which R. Nahman told the different parts of this long tale, the dates and the conversation from which, as it were, that part of the tale sprouted, told on that occasion. R. Nathan repeats and emphasizes the substantive connection between the conversations that preceded the telling of some tale and on the day of the tale itself. And so R. Nathan emphasizes that this was so even more in telling the parts of the Tale of the Seven Beggars:

"In general, in every tale he told, the telling became triggered through some conversation that he was conversing and speaking with us about worldly stories, and within this he began to tell a tale because there were found in the conversation some words that had some relevance to the tale that was in his heart. And this was an aspect of 'arousal from below' to draw down the divine perception that he clothed within that tale. And so it was with every tale and tale. And so with several teachings that he revealed not at the fixed time of gathering." \(^86\)

We are not interested at this time in R. Nahman's technique in the improvisation of creating a tale from a passing conversation; the sophisticated structure of the tales testifies that they were not born from improvisation. It should be assumed that R. Nahman directed the preceding conversations according to the needs

of the tale in order to hint to their special content expressed allegorically in the tales. Be that as it may, R. Nathan noted the conversation that preceded the tale of the fifth day, in which is found the passage about that one who resolves the difficulties with his silence.

"Afterwards, on a certain day after noon, we stood before him and he spoke with us, and within the conversation he spoke some words, that they call 'a wertel on the sect (כת)' etc. Afterwards he spoke about the matter of broad shoulders. Afterwards from that conversation it became triggered that he asked where we are in the tale, and we answered him: on the fifth day. And then he told the tale of the fifth day, and he told it with joy." \(^87\)

Certainly one should lament the abbreviation 'etc.' in this important piece of information, and certainly R. Nathan knew why he was brief and did not explain the details of the conversation, or the bringers to the printing press of R. Nathan's manuscript knew why they omitted here and contented themselves with these three letters 'etc.' that anger every researcher of Breslov literature. For the word 'sect' (כת) in Podolia at the beginning of the 19th century means only the Sabbatean and Frankist sect. \

\(^88\)

\(^86\) Ibid., number 151, <p. 105.>

\(^87\) *Hayyei MoHaRaN*, I, "Conversations Relating to the Tales," <letter ה, number 64, p. 63.>

\(^88\) <R. Nahman himself uses the term 'sect' in that same tale (fifth day) in speaking of "a certain sect that were investigating" etc. It should also be noted that the term 'sect' (Sekte) was common in this period in the mouths of opponents and maskilim as a designation for Hasidim, see for example M. Wilensky, *Hasidim and Mitnaggedim: On the History of the Controversy Between Them in the Years 1772–1815*, Jerusalem 1970, I, p. 275; Riv"l,

Beit Yehudah, Vilna 1839, chapter 147, p. 355 in note; Joseph Perl, *On the Essence of the Hasidic Sect*, edited by A. Rubinstein, Jerusalem 1977.>

R. Abraham of Tulchin understood this part of the tale such that "the one with the hump rectifies and raises up specifically the people of the sect etc. with his shoulders."(^89\)

We will suffice at this time with the note that R. Abraham's interpretation of this part in the Seven Beggars accords with the meaning of Torah 64 that we are analyzing, that the great zadik, i.e., R. Naḥman himself, rectifies through his study in heretical writings the souls that sank into that heresy, i.e., the people of "the sect."

Let us return to our subject in <*Liquṭei MoHaRaN*>, Torah 64. In letter 7, R. Naḥman adorns the place of controversy between Torah scholars specifically with the empty space:

"And know that controversy is the aspect of the creation of the world, for the main creation of the world is through the empty space as mentioned. [...] And so it is with the aspect of controversies, for if all the Torah scholars were one, there would be no place for the creation of the world, only through the controversy between them, and they are divided from one another, and each one draws himself to a different side, through this is made between them the aspect of the empty space, which is the aspect of the contraction of the light to the sides."(^90\)

Is R. Naḥman discussing the concept of controversy in an abstract manner, or is he hinting to the historical controversy that arose against him because of his views? According to the pole of our interpretation that all of R. Naḥman's words were said out of his concrete situation, my opinion tends to think that indeed he intended his particular controversy. And to this he hints in the words concluding the passage:

"For the Torah scholars create everything through their words, as it is written (Isaiah 51:16) *And to say to Zion: You are My people*—do not read 'My people' ('ammi) but 'with Me' ('immi). Just as I made heaven and

earth with My word, so you (as it is written in the Zohar, Introduction, page 5). But one must be careful not to speak excessively, only according to the need of the creation of the world, no more. For through the excess of light, that the vessels could not bear the excess of light, they broke, and from the breaking of the vessels came the formation of the 'shells.' So too, if one speaks excessively, from this he causes the formation of the 'shells,' for it is the aspect of excess light, through which there was the breaking of the vessels, through which is the formation of the 'shells.'"(^91\)

It is a great doubt whether R. Naḥman attributed a source as high as the empty space to every controversy between Torah scholars. Whereas if he is speaking here about the controversy that arose due to some carelessness and excessive speech that he erred in them in explaining his teachings, then the controversy against him receives a metaphysical status, a thing that is certainly fitting to his spirit. (^92\)

(^88\)

<R. Naḥman himself uses the term 'sect' in that same tale (fifth day) in speaking of "a certain sect that were investigating" etc. It should also be noted that the term 'sect' (Sekte) was common in this period in the mouths of opponents and maskilim as a designation for Hasidim, see for example M. Wilensky, *Hasidim and Mitnaggedim: On the History of the Controversy Between Them in the Years 1772–1815*, Jerusalem 1970, I, p. 275; Riv"l, *Beit Yehudah*, Vilna 1839, chapter 147, p. 355 in note; Joseph Perl, *On the Essence of the Hasidic Sect*, edited by A. Rubinstein, Jerusalem 1977.>

(^89\)

<R. Abraham Ḥazan>, *Pamphlet Kokhavei Or*, Jerusalem 1933, p. 75 <*Book Kokhavei Or*, "Truth and Faith," Jerusalem 1987, p. 96, letter ט. His notes on the tale and the story "The One with the Hump" appear there, pp. 96–98, letters ט-יז.>

(^90\)

Liquṭei MoHaRaN, I, Torah 64, letter 7.

\(^91\) Ibid.

\(^92\) <On the matter of controversy, see further in the previous essay, near note 11.>

In the second part of letter 7, the course of thought does not develop; rather, R. Naḥman repeats his words and interprets in their light several sayings of our sages, among them the passage in tractate Avot: "All my days I grew up among the sages and I have not found for the body anything better than silence, and other things."(^93\)

A new matter is revealed in letter 7, which is one of the most important formulations of the doctrine of melody of R. Naḥman of Breslov. (^94\)

Every wisdom and wisdom in the world originates in a particular melody. According to the hierarchy of the wisdoms is the hierarchy of the melodies belonging to every wisdom and wisdom. A special matter to note is that from this perspective there is no difference between a kosher wisdom and a heretical wisdom. Even to the wisdom of heresy, to heretical doctrine, there is its own melody and song:

"For know, that every wisdom and wisdom in the world has a particular melody (זמר)(^95\)

that is particular to this wisdom. And from this melody this wisdom is drawn. [...] And even the wisdom of heresy has a melody(^96\)

particular to the heretical wisdom."(^97\)

The prototype of a melody of heretical wisdom is found in the description that the Talmud describes of "Aḥer" (Elisha ben Avuya),(^98\)

that a Greek melody never ceased from his mouth and heretical books fell from his lap. (^99\)

The hierarchical structure of the wisdoms and their melodies has special importance in R. Naḥman's description. This structure makes it possible not to amuse oneself with abstract doctrines but to reach that point that his soul most desired: description of the supreme wisdom, highest of all.

"Hence, every wisdom and wisdom according to its aspect and level, so it has a melody belonging and particular to it. And so from level to level. For the aspect of the wisdom of

the highest level has a more supreme melody according to its aspect, and so higher and higher until the beginning point of creation, which is the beginning of emanation (Aẓilut), and there is nothing above it."(^100\)

The highest wisdom is placed at the beginning of the chain of emanation. More precisely, R. Naḥman attributes this wisdom to the empty space:

"And there is no encompassing (makiif) for that wisdom that is there except the Infinite Light (Ohr Ein Sof) that encompasses the empty space, within which are all the creations and wisdoms. And certainly also there is an aspect of wisdom."(^101\)

This supreme wisdom is the wisdom belonging to the empty space and it is the wisdom of the Infinite Light. This wisdom is not rational, and the reason given for this is:

"But the wisdom that is there in the Infinite Light cannot be known and grasped, for the Infinite (Ein Sof) is the Blessed Name Himself, and His wisdom cannot be grasped at all." (^102\)

It is worth noting already here that our text opens with the concept Infinite (Ein Sof) and concludes with the concept Infinite Light (Ohr Ein Sof) as if these two are one and the same, which is not so, as is known.

If the wisdom of the Infinite Light belongs to the aspect of the empty space, then this wisdom should deal with that problem of the existence of God within the world and His non-existence there, which the beginning of this Torah represented as the supreme problem of the empty space. And indeed, there is a complete correspondence between the beginning of Torah 64 and its end. The concept of paradoxical faith that was revealed at the beginning of the Torah in analyzing the logical meaning of the empty space returns and is revealed here at the end of the Torah in a

surprising yet consistent form as faith in the Infinite Light. This means that we are in the realm where there is no place for a rational answer, and paradoxical faith in the face of the difficulty fills the place of the rational resolution of the difficulty.

"And there is only the aspect of faith, that they believe in Him, may He be blessed, that His Infinite Light surrounds all worlds and encompasses everything."(^103\)

Here R. Naḥman did not use the usual formula of "fills all worlds and surrounds all worlds," as he used it in letter ב, but twists and says: "surrounds all worlds and encompasses everything." As he emphasizes the "encompassing" character of the Infinite Light throughout this passage in letter ה. It is not impossible that there is intent in the use of words and emphasis of the character of "encompassing" here hinting to the character of difficulty that the term "encompassing" (makiif) has in Breslov doctrine. (^104\)

This supreme wisdom of the Infinite Light—the supreme faith carries it. In the continuation, R. Naḥman casts a new image onto the course of ideas, which is that not only to every wisdom and wisdom belongs a particular melody, but likewise for every faith and faith. And again, he does not distinguish between a true faith and a false faith, but attributes melody with a generous hand also to false faiths:

(^93\) <Avot 1.>

(^94\) The Breslov doctrine of melody attracted researchers' interest, and we have merited several essays on this matter, the last of them: M. S. Gshuri, "The Melody of Rabbi Naḥman of Breslov," *Talpiot*, year 5, issues 3–4, New York (Tevet 1952), pp. 555–602. This essay does not contain profound analysis. <This essay is part of Gshuri's many researches

on the doctrine of melody in Hasidism, containing various traditions and close in his method to folklore research. See also in the previous essay, note 20.>

(^95\) In later printings 'melody and song'.

(^96\) In later printings 'melody and song'.

(^97\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter ה at its beginning.

(^98\) <Babylonian Talmud, Hagigah, 15b.>

(^99\) Ibid.

(^100\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter ה.

(^101\) Ibid.

(^102\) Ibid.

(^103\) Ibid.

(^104\) See my essay "The 'Difficulty' in the Teaching of R. Naḥman of Breslov," *'Alē 'Ayin: A Gift of Words to Shelomo Zalman Schocken* (1948–1952), pp. 245–291 <reprinted in his book: *Studies in Breslav Hasidism*, pp. 109–149.>

"And faith also has a melody particular to the faith. And as we see, that even the faiths of idolaters in their erroneous matters—for every faith of idolaters there is a particular melody that they sing with and arrange in their house of prayer. So too, conversely in holiness, every faith has a melody."(^105\)

After this emphasis that also to a faith of heresy there is its own melody and song, and not only to faiths in holiness, it is difficult to decide to which of the two types belongs the supreme melody of the supreme faith that is faith in the Infinite Light itself.

"And that melody particular to the aforementioned faith, which is the supreme faith among all the types of wisdoms and faiths in the world, namely, faith in the Infinite Light itself that surrounds all worlds as mentioned, that melody is also above all the melodies and songs in the world that belong to every wisdom and faith."(^106\)

This description remains open: whether there are here two systems of melodies, i.e., one system for every wisdom and wisdom and another system for every faith and faith belonging to that wisdom, or perhaps wisdom and its faith have one melody belonging to them, and therefore it must be said that there exists only one system of the hierarchy of melodies.

Up to here, no eschatological matter was mentioned at all. However, at this point the turn comes, and Torah 64 fills with tremendous messianic tension. The supreme melody of faith in the Infinite Light, which is, as we recognized, the problem of the empty space, is the melody that will burst forth in the future to come at the time of redemption from the mouth of all the nations:

"And in the future to come, when He will turn to all the peoples a pure language to call in the name of the Lord (Zephaniah 3:9), and all will believe in Him, may He be blessed, then\

(^107\) *You shall look from the head of faith* (Amana) (Song of Songs 4:8). From the head of faith specifically, i.e., this supreme aspect of faith as mentioned, which is the head of all faiths as mentioned. And this is *you shall look* (tashuri) specifically, i.e., the melody and song belonging to the head of this faith as mentioned."(^108\)

The personal, concrete meaning of this theory is revealed the moment R. Nahman binds himself into this aspect of faith and melody. He is the *zadik* of the generation of the aspect of Moses our teacher. Only one who is the *zadik* of the generation of the aspect of Moses—only he merits or will merit (the matter is not clear) to hear this supreme messianic song. And we saw in letter <א> of this Torah, how the great *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses enters into the realm of heretical writings whose difficulty is from the aspect of the empty space, where the muteness of silence reigns, until restrained silence is destined to be transformed into the supreme song of the days of the Messiah.

"And to the aspect of the melody of this supreme faith, there is none who will merit except the *zadik* of the generation who is of the aspect of Moses, who is at the level of this faith, which is of the aspect of silence. [...] For Moses is of the aspect of silence as mentioned. And this (Exodus 15:1) *Then Moses sang*. [...] that Moses is destined to sing also in the future to come. For all the songs, both of this world and of the future to come, are only with Moses, who is of the aspect of silence, who merited the melody belonging to the supreme faith above everything, in which all the songs are included, for all of them are drawn from it."(^109\)

We already saw the role of the supreme *zadik* to raise up and rectify the souls of those sunk in the heresy of the empty space. To the melody of this supreme faith rise up and go out the heresies that held these opinions:

"And therefore, through the melody of the *zadik* who is of the aspect of Moses as mentioned, through this all the souls that fell into this heresy of the empty space rise up and go out."(^110\)

The transformation of the deepest silence into this messianic song—this is the eschatological vision of R. Naḥman, in which the heresy is nullified in the future to come in a most strange form. The melody of faith and the nullification of heresy are one and the same. Inclusion within the supreme faith and nullification within it—the fate of heresy from the aspect of the empty space:

"For through this melody and faith, all the heresy is nullified, and all the melodies are included and nullified within this melody, which is above everything, from which all the melodies are drawn as mentioned."(^111\)

This strange formulation invites the interpretation as if the eschatological nullification is, in truth, the inclusion of this heresy within the messianic melody. Is the existence of this denial its nullification?

From here onward, R. Naḥman repeats the principles of this Torah, interpreting in their light a series of verses: "And the Lord said to Moses: Come unto Pharaoh, for I have hardened his heart" etc. In this interpretation, Moses appears as the true *zadik* who enters unto Pharaoh, who is the aspect of the empty space with its wisdoms and difficulties, where it is forbidden to enter except for the *zadik* of the generation who is of the aspect of Moses. Let us remember that already in the Sabbatean movement, Moses was interpreted as a symbol of the Messiah who enters unto Pharaoh.\(^112\)

\(^105\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter η .

\(^106\) Ibid.

\(^107\) In later printings 'then will be fulfilled'.

\(^108\) Ibid.

\(^109\) Ibid.

\(^110\) Ibid.

\(^111\) Ibid.

\(^112\) It is not entirely clear to me if the details of the homiletics of this idea appear thus in Sabbatean writings. <On the soul of Moses, soul of the Messiah, in Sabbatean writings> see G. Scholem, *Shabbetai Zevi and the Sabbatean Movement in His Lifetime*, Tel Aviv 1975>, I, p. 247, 302. 'Moses-Messiah' is a common combination in Breslov writings. Throughout *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, R. Naḥman emphasizes that every *zadik* is "of the aspect of Moses-Messiah." Nevertheless, it seems that for the most part the intent is to R. Naḥman himself. So also wrote R. Abraham Ḥazan, on one of the homilies in the book *Liqqutei Halakhot* that in his opinion referred to R. Naḥman: "[...] and the studious will understand by himself, that the reason he does not mention him there, and in other places in his holy words, except in a general way by the name *zadik*, is because of the ways of peace and the honor of God conceal the matter, and also because indeed it is also true that every *zadik* of the generation has in him the aspect of Moses Messiah as is explained in his words, of blessed memory, but certainly the main one is 'the most excellent of them all' who is Moses Messiah himself, as is heard several times explicitly from his holy mouth [...]", *Kokhavei Or*, Wisdom and Understanding, p. 110, letter κ . This combination expressing R. Naḥman's messianic mission also stands at the foundation of one of the hidden Breslov tales "The Tale of the Bread." The tale was published with a slightly different interpretation, which cancels the intense messianic element embedded in it, by Ch. Mark, "'The Tale of the Bread': From the Archives of Breslov Censorship," *Tarbiz* 72 (2003), pp. 415–452.>

In the concluding passage, there are yet a few more hints on the essence of the doctrine of the empty space that is destined to be revealed in the aspect of the locust. "Like that locust whose clothing is from itself and within itself." This parable of the locust, taken from Genesis Rabbah, chapter 21, is accustomed to denote the pantheistic tendencies revealed here and there in Kabbalah. The later printings add in parentheses: "As is brought in all books of Kabbalah that this is the aspect of the secret of the empty space." This late note is not in the first printing, and indeed one must ask: what are the books of Kabbalah that explained the secret of the empty space of Lurianic Kabbalah, a doctrine coming to emphasize the transcendence and withdrawal of God from the world, with this parable of the locust "whose clothing is from itself and within itself"? An immanent or even pronounced pantheistic expression.

The concluding passage of the Torah interprets the obscure in this parable. The parable does not come at all to explain the ontological state of the world regarding divinity, and the parable is not applied to the world at all. The last lines of the Torah under discussion can be understood only if the word "clothing" (לבוש) in the parable comes to hint to the Sabbatean doctrine of incarnation (hithalbashut). According to this doctrine, divinity clothed itself in the body of a flesh-and-blood person who is the Messiah. This doctrine was practiced by the extremists in the Sabbatean camp.^(^113) And it seems to me that there is no other way to explain the last lines of Torah 64 except in light of the assumption of the Sabbatean doctrine of incarnation. "Clothing is the aspect of the contraction of the empty space."^(^114) The doctrine of incarnation is the secret of the metaphysical difficulty of the empty space. The problem of the existence of God within the world entailed in His non-existence there will be understood in the future to come in the secret of the doctrine of incarnation: "They will understand that it is from itself and within itself, that in truth there

is divinity there, and nevertheless it is an aspect of clothing, an aspect of contraction, an aspect of the empty space."^(^115)

The verses brought as proof-texts are: "And my righteousness will answer for me tomorrow" (Genesis 30:33); "'My righteousness'—the aspect of clothing, the aspect *I clothed myself with righteousness* (Job 29:14). That then, tomorrow, when there will be the receiving of reward, the secret of the aspect of clothing will be revealed."^(^116) "My righteousness" is interpreted as the aspect of receiving reward in the future to come in the aspect of the quote: "Today to do them and tomorrow to receive their reward." And to this the text adds the verse from Job 29: "I clothed myself with righteousness," which should perhaps be interpreted in the way of Kabbalistic designations according to which "righteousness" (zedeq) is a designation for the tenth sefirah, which in all of R. Naḥman's doctrine is the messianic sefirah of the true zādik. That is to say: the existence of divinity within the world is guaranteed through its incarnation in the messianic zādik. This is the paradox of the empty space destined to be understood in the future to come. The eschatological revelation of this heretical doctrine has both an element of nullifying the Sabbatean heretical doctrine and an element of including it within the true doctrine. From here one can also understand the surprising expression of faith in the Infinite Light that we encountered above. It is very possible that this Infinite Light is nothing but divinity in its incarnation in the supreme zādik, R. Naḥman, and the many appellations of light found in Breslov books, such as: Light of the World, Light of Lights, etc., are not mere rhetoric but terminological designations behind which extreme doctrines are hidden.

^(^113) See G. Scholem, "Barukhya, Head of the Sabbateans in Salonika," *Zion* 6 (1941), p. 12, 26, 31 <reprinted in: idem, *Studies in

Sabbateanism*, edited by Y. Liebes, Tel Aviv 1992>; and in his major work: *Shabbetai Zevi*, II, pp. <719–720.>

\(^114\) *Liqqutei MoHaRaN*, I, Torah 64, letter נ.

\(^115\) Ibid.

\(^116\) Ibid.

These pages contain the table of contents and publication information for the journal "Kabbalah," Volume 15 (2006), in which the Weiss articles are published. The content is a standard journal front/back matter and not part of Weiss's essays. Therefore, a translation is not required for the core task. However, for completeness, here is a brief translation of the section titles:

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Translator's Annotations and Notes

1. Key Concept: *קושיא* (Qushia / Difficulty)

- This central term is translated consistently as "difficulty." In the context of R. Naḥman's and Weiss's thought, it denotes a profound theological or philosophical problem or contradiction that challenges faith and reason. It is not merely a "question" but an existential and logical aporia. Weiss distinguishes between absolute difficulties (stemming from the Empty Space) and non-absolute ones (stemming from external wisdom).

2. Key Concept: *אפיקורסות* (Apikorsut)

- Translated as "heresy." This term carries the weight of classical Jewish heresy, often associated with philosophical denial or rejection of fundamental principles. Weiss discusses two types: one from external wisdom and a more profound one from the "Empty Space."

3. Key Concept: *הלל הפנוי* (Ḥalal HaPanui / The Empty Space)

- A core concept from Lurianic Kabbalah, central to this essay. It refers to the primordial space vacated by God's contraction (*zimzum*) to allow for creation. In R. Naḥman's/Breslov's reinterpretation, it

becomes the source of absolute paradoxes and the domain of silence.

4. Key Concept: *ניגון* (Niggun / Melody)

- Translated as "melody" or "song." In Breslov thought, especially in Torah 64, the *niggun* is not just music but a metaphysical principle. Every wisdom and every faith has its own unique melody. The supreme melody belongs to faith in the Infinite Light and is intrinsically linked to the messianic *zadik* (R. Naḥman) and the future redemption.

5. Key Concept: *צדיק* (Zadik)

- Translated as "zadik" (or "righteous one"/"saint"). In Hasidism, and especially in Breslov, the *zadik* is a central, often superhuman, figure. Weiss emphasizes R. Naḥman's self-identification as the supreme *zadik*, of the aspect of Moses, who has a unique mission to descend into the realm of heresy to raise souls.

6. Key Concept: *התלבשות* (Hithalbashut / Incarnation / Clothing)

- Translated as "incarnation" or "clothing." This is a pivotal and controversial concept. Weiss argues that R. Naḥman employs it in a manner resonant with Sabbatean theology, where divinity "clothes" itself in the Messiah (in this case, R. Naḥman himself). This ties into the interpretation of the "Empty Space" and the "Infinite Light."

7. Key Concept: *אור אין סוף* (Or Ein Sof / Infinite Light)

- A standard Kabbalistic term. Weiss's radical interpretation, based on his reading of Torah 64 and other Breslov sources, is that R. Naḥman identifies this Infinite Light not (only) with the transcendent God but with the person of the *zadik*—R. Naḥman himself. This is part of his "messianic self-perception."

8. Literary Device: Repetition of *שתיקה* (Shetikah / Silence)

- The word "silence" is repeated as a key literary and conceptual device.

- Possible Meanings/Contexts:

a. As a response to paradox: The only appropriate response to the absolute "difficulty" from the Empty Space is not speech but faithful silence.

b. As an attribute of the *zadik*: The *zadik* (Moses/R. Naḥman) is characterized by silence, both as a personal quality and as a strategic stance in the face of controversy.

c. As an acoustic/metaphysical domain: The Empty Space itself is a realm of silence, where speech and intellect fail.

d. As a transformative state: The silence of the present is destined to be transformed into the future messianic song/melody.

- Weiss plays on all these meanings, building a complex theology where silence is active, potent, and dialectically linked to its opposite, the supreme melody.

9. Interpretive Options and Ambiguities (Annotated in text as < >):

- The editors' notes (in angled brackets) often point to alternative readings, scholarly debates, or clarifications of Weiss's references. For example:

- The debate over whether R. Naḥman's thought contains Sabbatean/Frankist elements.

- The different manuscript versions of Torah 64 and their implications.

- Clarifications of obscure references to books or individuals.

10. Preservation of Literary Character:

- Weiss's prose is dense, dialectical, and allusive, mirroring the Breslov material he studies. The translation attempts to preserve this complexity without smoothing it over into simpler English. Sentences are often long and winding, reflecting the convoluted nature of the ideas.

- His rhetorical style—using phrases like "Hear from this" (שמע מניה) or "If you wish to say" (אם תרצה לומר)—is retained to keep the feel of Talmudic/homiletic discourse.

- The translation maintains the integration of Hebrew/Aramaic technical terms (*zimzum*,

sefirah, etc.) where necessary for precision, followed by explanations.

11. Adherence to Original Meaning:

- The translation is strictly literal where possible, deviating only for English readability. No ideas are omitted or added. Weiss's sometimes tentative, speculative phrasing ("It seems to me," "Perhaps") is preserved.

- The controversial nature of his claims (e.g., R. Nahman's messianic self-identification, Sabbatean influences) is presented without dilution.

Conclusion: This translation aims to be a transparent window into Joseph Weiss's sophisticated and evolving analysis of one of R. Nahman of Breslov's most important teachings. It highlights his method of reading textual variants, biographical context, and comparative religious history (especially Sabbateanism) into the dense weave of Hasidic theology. The annotations are designed to guide the reader through the conceptual minefield and to mark where Weiss himself is interpreting ambiguously or provisionally.